

SLOTHOLUMULE: THE DEEPER TRUTH

A sloth hero fights cult lies in the forest.





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CHAPTER 1



A Forest Without Fairness

The market bell cracked through the clearing just as a wooden cart overturned.

Apples rolled across the packed earth beneath the fern-lined main trail. A young rabbit lunged after them, but a boot blocked his path. The boot belonged to a tall human in a gray coat, one of several strangers who had begun appearing near the forest's busiest paths. He kicked an apple aside and seized the rabbit by the collar.

"Move along," he said. "This stall is reserved."

"It's my family's stall," the rabbit protested. "We paid for the space."

The human held up a black token stamped with a white, flattened circle. "Not anymore."

Slotholumule watched from beneath the crooked limb of an old cedar. His claws pressed into the bark. Around him, the clearing kept moving. Birds carried baskets between stalls. Turtles waited in a line for water. Foxes slipped through the crowd with bundles tucked under their arms. Everyone saw the rabbit dangling from the stranger's hand.

No one stopped.

A bell rang again. A vendor lowered her eyes. Two squirrels quietly dragged their fruit stand three steps away.

Slotholumule had come to the clearing for one simple thing: to deliver medicine to the families living beyond the main trail. The small packet rested in his satchel, wrapped

in waxed leaves. Swiftwing had trusted him to bring it before sunset. If he stayed hidden much longer, the medicine would not reach Stoneback's neighbors in time.

But the rabbit's feet scraped helplessly against the dirt.

"Put him down," Slotholumule said.

The words came out softer than he intended. The human looked toward the cedar.

"Who said that?"

Slotholumule stepped into the open. His slow limbs made the crowd part with uneasy murmurs. He wore a plain shirt marked with the words "4M Face," a slogan he had painted there himself after hearing too many creatures told that fairness was a privilege instead of a right.

The human dropped the rabbit. He landed hard, clutching his shoulder.

"You should keep walking, sloth," the stranger said.

"I'm not walking away."

A fox near the spice stall gave a nervous laugh. "That is exactly what everyone does here."

The human's companions turned. One carried a club. Another wore a red cord around his wrist. The white circle on their tokens matched the symbol painted on several crates stacked beside the trail.

Slotholumule's gaze moved across the clearing. A turtle vendor had been shoved from the shade into the hot dust. A bird with one bent wing was being charged twice the usual price for a handful of grain. At the far end of the market, a family of possums stood behind a rope while better-dressed animals passed through a gate marked with a fresh sign: AUTHORIZED CREATURES ONLY.

The injustices were not separate accidents. They fitted together like boards in a cage.

The human in gray pointed at the rabbit. "He has no permit."

"He paid for one."

"Permits can be withdrawn."

"By whom?"

The human smiled without warmth. "By those who keep order."

A low rumble moved through the crowd. It was not agreement. It was fear trying to become a voice.

Slotholumule felt the medicine packet tug against his side as he shifted. He could leave now, reach the families, and avoid making the clearing worse. He could tell himself that one confrontation would not change the forest. He could tell himself that peace meant silence.

Then the gray-coated human reached for the rabbit again.

Slotholumule moved.

His claws caught the man's wrist before the hand closed. The human's skin was hot beneath his grip. For a heartbeat, the clearing went silent except for the clatter of one last apple rolling in a circle.

"Let him stand," Slotholumule said.

The man jerked free and shoved him. Slotholumule stumbled into a stall, sending jars of red berries crashing across the ground. Glass broke. The vendor cried out.

"You damaged private goods," the man said. "Now you owe us."

"Those jars fell because you attacked me."

"Then perhaps the forest should charge you for resisting."

The club carrier stepped forward.

A blur dropped from the branches above. Swiftwing struck the carrier's wrist with one sharp wingbeat. The club spun into a basket of onions.

"Perhaps the forest should charge you for missing," Swiftwing said.

The crowd gasped. Slotholumule looked up at the bird, startled and relieved.

"Swiftwing, I told you to stay near the medicine route."

"And I told you not to confront armed bullies alone."

A heavy shell pushed through the crowd. Stoneback planted himself beside the overturned cart, his broad feet grinding glass into the dirt.

"Back away," he said.

The gray-coated man stared at the turtle. "You think a shell makes you dangerous?"

"No," Stoneback replied. "The people behind me do."

For the first time, the crowd shifted toward them instead of away. The rabbit rose, shaking. The bird with the bent wing edged closer. The possum family pressed against the rope, watching.

A small brown possum slipped under it and hurried to Slotholumule's side.

"Perry," the possum whispered. "Perry the Possum."

"I know," Slotholumule said. "You helped Wiseclaw carry books last winter."

Perry nodded toward the far trail. "The strangers have taken over the water station too. They're turning away anyone without those tokens."

A sharp whistle cut through the market.

The gray-coated man straightened. From the roof of the old trading house, a figure in a dark cloak watched the clearing. The face remained hidden, but a silver pin glinted at the throat, shaped like the flattened white circle.

“Leave,” the figure called. “This disturbance has been noted.”

The human in gray smiled again. “You heard them.”

Slotholumule looked from the cloaked watcher to the token in the man’s hand. The same mark. The same command. The same promise that order belonged to whoever seized it first.

“What is that symbol?” Thumper asked.

The rabbit had found his voice. He stood beside Slotholumule, rubbing his bruised shoulder. “They say it comes from the crater.”

At the word crater, several vendors flinched.

Wiseclaw, the old owl who had been observing from a signpost, spread his wings and dropped lightly to the ground. “The crater beyond the northern ridge,” he said. “The one now flying a banner that reads Flat Earth HQ.”

A murmur rolled through the clearing.

Slotholumule had heard rumors: strangers preaching that the world was shaped by secret rulers, that truth belonged only to those who claimed it, that every disagreement proved an enemy was hiding nearby. He had dismissed the talk as foolishness.

But foolishness did not seize water stations. Foolishness did not mark families with ropes.

The gray-coated man raised his voice. “Flat Earth HQ protects this forest from confusion. Those who cooperate will receive food, shelter, and access. Those who spread disorder will be removed.”

"Removed where?" Swiftwing asked.

The man's eyes narrowed. "Beyond the safe paths."

Stoneback lowered his head. "That sounds like a threat."

"It is a promise."

The club carrier recovered his weapon and swung. Stoneback caught the blow against his shell. The impact rang like a struck bell. Slotholumule grabbed the rabbit and pulled him aside as another attacker rushed in.

The market erupted.

Baskets overturned. Wings beat the air. Someone screamed for the guards, but the guards were already wearing the white tokens. A turtle fell near the well, and Slotholumule crawled between him and a pair of boots. The boots kicked his shoulder. Pain flashed down his arm.

He clung to the ground, then hooked one claw around the attacker's ankle. The human toppled into a pile of empty crates.

"Run!" Wiseclaw called. "They're closing the trail!"

At the northern entrance, three more figures dragged a chain across the path. Beyond them, the forest road vanished into dense green shadow.

The medicine.

Slotholumule looked toward the satchel. Its strap had torn. The packet lay in the dust beneath a broken jar.

Perry darted for it, but a token-wearing stranger grabbed him by the tail.

Slotholumule felt something inside him settle into place.

He did not roar. He did not charge blindly. He reached for the nearest fallen pole, braced it beneath the stranger's arm, and levered him away from Perry. The possum dropped free. Slotholumule caught the medicine packet with his other hand.

"Take this to Swiftwing," he told Perry. "Follow the creek. Do not use the main trail."

Perry stared at him. "What about you?"

"I'm staying."

The gray-coated man wiped blood from his lip. "You are making a serious mistake."

"No," Slotholumule said. He climbed onto the overturned cart so every creature in the clearing could see him. "The mistake was believing peace requires us to accept cruelty."

The words carried farther than his voice should have managed. Creatures froze around the market: the rabbit, the bent-winged bird, the turtle by the well, the possum family behind the rope. Even the attackers hesitated.

Slotholumule lifted the torn medicine satchel above his head.

"No token decides who deserves water. No banner decides who belongs on this trail. Fairness is not a favor handed down by strangers. It belongs to every creature here."

The gray-coated man raised two fingers.

From the trading-house roof, the cloaked figure answered with a second whistle. More movement stirred beyond the stalls. Shapes appeared between the trees, too many to count.

Stoneback stepped onto the cart beside Slotholumule. Swiftwing landed on the rail. Thumper emerged from beneath a toppled table, ears pinned back but eyes bright.

Wiseclaw's voice dropped low. "They were waiting for someone to resist."

Slotholumule looked toward the northern ridge. Through gaps in the branches, he could just see a strip of black fabric stretched above the distant crater. White letters flashed in the afternoon light.

FLAT EARTH HQ.

The market had been loud with ordinary life only moments before. Now every path seemed watched.

The rabbit moved to Slotholumule's side. "If we leave together, they can't pretend this was one troublemaker."

The bent-winged bird joined him. Then the turtle rose from the dust. One by one, creatures crossed the clearing and stood beneath the broken cart.

The gray-coated man took a step back, but his expression hardened.

"You have no idea who you've challenged," he said.

Slotholumule tightened his grip on the satchel. His shoulder burned. His claws were cut from the glass. Behind him, the forest waited with all its old unfairness. Ahead, the white symbol marked a power that had begun reaching into every street, every well, every story told beneath the trees.

"Then we'll find out," he said.

Somewhere beyond the market, a horn sounded from the direction of the crater.

The cloaked figure vanished from the roof.

And the forest's new defenders stepped toward the northern trail.

CHAPTER 2

The 4M Face Promise

The northern trail vanished beneath Slotholumule's slow, steady hands as he pulled himself over the stump platform. Bark scraped his palms. Below, the forest animals pressed close, their voices rising from the clearing where the market cart had overturned.

"Let him speak!" Thumper shouted.

"Speak about what?" a fox called back. "The cloaked stranger? The broken cart? Or the trouble he plans to drag behind him?"

Slotholumule reached the top and faced them. The cracked market bell still swung in the distance, giving off a thin, uneven chime. Dust clung to his shirt, but the words across his chest remained clear.

4M FACE.

The promise had started as paint and cloth. Now every eye in the clearing seemed fixed on it.

"Fairness for all creatures," Slotholumule said.

A murmur rolled through the crowd.

He had wanted one thing: not applause, not obedience, but a commitment. The market had shown him how quickly the strong could decide who received help and who was left beneath an overturned cart. The forest could not keep calling that peace.

"Fairness sounds gentle," said Roost from the edge of the gathering. The bird's feathers were ruffled from the flight north. "But some creatures hear it as a threat."

"They hear it that way because they are used to being above everyone else," Thumper said.

Stoneback shifted beside the stump, his heavy shell bumping the platform's roots. "Careful. Anger can break a door. It cannot always build what comes after."

Slotholumule looked from one ally to the next. Swiftwing perched on a low branch, watching the crowd with sharp, restless eyes. Wiseclaw stood in the shade behind the platform, silent but alert. Perry the Possum kept one paw pressed to the bruise on his shoulder from the overturned cart.

Their presence gave Slotholumule courage. It also made the danger plain. They had stepped onto the northern trail together, but a group was not yet a movement. A movement needed a promise others could trust.

He lifted one paw.

"No creature should lose food because of its size. No creature should be silenced because of its voice. No creature should be pushed from a path because another claims the ground belongs to them."

A rabbit near the front lowered her ears. A young bird leaned forward. Across the clearing, a badger folded his arms.

"And who decides what is fair?" the badger demanded. "You?"

"No," Slotholumule said. "We decide together."

The answer struck harder than he expected. For a moment, no one spoke.

Then a stone snapped against the platform.

It struck Slotholumule's shirt and dropped into the dust.

“Pretty words from a slow-moving troublemaker,” called a voice from behind the crowd. “The forest was safer before he painted a slogan on his chest.”

Several animals turned. A pair of human-made black badges glinted at the speaker’s neck. The mark was small, but Slotholumule recognized it from the distant ridge where the Flat Earth HQ banner had first appeared above the crater.

The speaker smiled when he saw Slotholumule notice.

“Flat Earth HQ keeps order,” he said. “Their truth is simple. Their rules are clear.”

“Clear rules can still be cruel,” Wiseclaw said.

The badger with folded arms glanced toward the badge. “And what happens when these new defenders disagree? Do we get another overturned cart?”

Perry’s paw tightened against his bruise. “The cart overturned because the wheel was cracked. Everyone saw that.”

“Everyone saw the mess,” the badger replied. “Not everyone saw who caused it.”

The accusation moved through the crowd like cold water. Slotholumule felt the platform’s rough grain beneath his claws. The crowd wanted proof, but proof was fragile when those in power controlled the story.

He could climb down and let the argument fade. He could wait until the team reached the crater, until the cult’s threat became impossible to deny.

But waiting had already cost too much.

Slotholumule stepped to the platform’s edge. “Bring me the cracked wheel.”

Thumper blinked. “Now?”

“Now.”

The rabbit darted through the crowd. Animals shifted aside, some reluctantly, some with sudden interest. She returned dragging the broken wheel by its iron rim. Splinters bristled from the hub.

Slotholumule lowered himself beside it. The wood smelled of fresh sap and dust. He ran a claw along the split.

"This wheel was repaired three times," he said. "Each repair was hidden beneath new paint."

The cart owner, a thin deer, stared at the ground.

The badger snorted. "That proves neglect. It does not prove injustice."

"It proves someone knew the cart was unsafe and kept sending others to pull it," Slotholumule answered. "The largest creatures were given the heaviest loads. The smallest were blamed when the cart failed."

The deer raised her head. "I was told the market could not afford a new wheel."

"Who told you?"

She glanced at the black-badged speaker.

The crowd went quiet.

The speaker's smile vanished. "Be careful, sloth."

Slotholumule felt the old fear move through him, slow but sharp. The warning was not meant only for him. It was meant for every creature watching.

He placed the broken wheel upright against the stump. "This is what happens when silence is called peace."

The sentence hung over the clearing.

Then Swiftwing dropped from the branch, landing beside him. "And this is what happens when someone speaks alone." The bird faced the crowd. "The rest of us stand close."

Stoneback moved forward next. His shell scraped against the stump's roots with a deep grinding sound. Thumper came after him, ears high. Wiseclaw stepped from the shade. Perry the Possum joined them, still favoring one shoulder.

Five bodies formed a line behind Slotholumule.

Not a wall. A promise.

The badger looked at them and shook his head. "A rabbit, a bird, a turtle, a fox, and a sloth. That is not enough to protect a forest."

"Then stand with us," Thumper said.

The badger's eyes narrowed. "Against whom?"

Before Slotholumule could answer, a sharp whistle cut across the clearing.

A black-feathered dart buried itself in the stump inches from Slotholumule's paw.

Panic burst through the animals. Wings beat. Claws scratched earth. Someone screamed that the cult had come.

"Stay together!" Slotholumule called.

Another dart struck the platform. This one carried a strip of black cloth marked with a white circle.

Flat Earth HQ.

The badge-wearing speaker slipped backward into the crowd.

Roost launched into the air. "There!"

The bird dove toward the fleeing figure, but a thrown branch forced Roost aside. Thumper leaped over the platform's edge and vanished between the legs of the scattering animals.

Slotholumule climbed down as quickly as his body allowed. A fallen basket rolled into his path, spilling red berries across the dust. He caught himself against a tree trunk, then saw the young rabbit who had carried the wheel trapped beneath a tangle of market cloth.

He turned toward the fleeing spy.

The choice lasted less than a breath.

Slotholumule seized the cloth and pulled. The fabric tore with a loud rip. He dragged the rabbit free just as another dart struck the tree above them.

"Run!" he said.

"I can run," she gasped.

"Then run beside me."

They reached the stump as the crowd regrouped. The spy was gone. So was the black-badged speaker.

But the clearing had changed. Fear had replaced curiosity. Several animals hurried toward the southern paths. Others stared at the darts lodged in the wood.

The badger remained.

"So," he said, voice low, "your promise brought them here."

Slotholumule looked at the frightened rabbit beside him, at Perry's bruised shoulder, at the black cloth trembling from the dart.

"No," he said. "They were already here. We only made them visible."

The badger studied him. "And when they come for us?"

Slotholumule pulled the dart from the stump. Its shaft was cold and smooth. "Then we do not face them alone."

"That is a promise too."

"It is."

The badger looked toward the northern trail, where the branches knitted into a dark passage. "Promises do not stop arrows."

"No," Stoneback said. "But a united forest can stop the hand that throws them."

The badger's jaw tightened. He glanced at the animals still gathered around the platform. "What do you want from us?"

Slotholumule held up the broken wheel in one paw and the cult's dart in the other.

"Stand together. Speak when someone is pushed aside. Refuse the cult's stories when they are used to make neighbors fear one another. And when we reach the crater, help us uncover what Flat Earth HQ is hiding."

A gray hare stepped forward. Then a pair of sparrows. The young rabbit stood at Slotholumule's side, shaking but upright.

The badger exhaled through his nose. "I will stand with you for one day."

"One day is enough to begin," Slotholumule said.

"Do not mistake that for trust."

"I will not."

The badger extended one paw. Slotholumule clasped it. The grip was brief and hard, but it carried weight.

More creatures edged closer.

Swiftwing landed on the stump. "They will return."

"I know," Slotholumule said.

Perry looked at the dart. "And next time they may bring more than warnings."

Wiseclaw's gaze traveled toward the northern trail. "The cloaked figure vanished from the roof for a reason. Someone is watching the path ahead."

A chill moved through Slotholumule despite the warm afternoon. He remembered the dark shape disappearing above the market, the feeling that unseen eyes had followed every step since the cart overturned.

The clearing had given him what he asked for: not a crowd, but a fragile circle. It was small enough to break. It was real enough to defend.

He climbed back onto the stump platform. The animals gathered below, no longer shouting over one another.

"Tomorrow at first light," he said, "we leave for the northern trail. We cross the mountains, the rivers, and the deep forest. We find the crater. We learn what Flat Earth HQ is building beneath that banner."

The young rabbit raised her voice. "And if they attack?"

Slotholumule looked at the dart in his paw.

"Then we protect one another without becoming what they are."

The words settled over the clearing. No cheer followed. No easy victory. Instead, the gray hare moved beside the badger. The sparrows clustered near Roost. Perry the Possum stood straighter despite his bruised shoulder.

Thumper grinned up at the platform. "That is more than a slogan."

Slotholumule touched the 4M Face mark on his shirt. "It has to be."

From somewhere beyond the trees came a distant metallic hum, too deep for any forest machine. The animals fell silent.

Far to the north, hidden beyond mountain and river, the Flat Earth HQ banner stirred above the crater.

The circle around Slotholumule tightened.

"We will follow," the badger said. "But we need proof you can protect us."

Slotholumule closed his paw around the cult's dart.

"Then we will earn it on the trail."

CHAPTER 3

Flat Earth HQ Revealed

“Then we will earn it on the trail.”

The words still clung to Slotholumule as he climbed the northern ridge, the cult’s dart tucked beneath his belt. Its black feather scratched his fur whenever he moved. Below, the forest fell away into a vast crater, raw and red beneath the afternoon sun.

A banner stretched between two iron poles above the rim.

FLAT EARTH HQ.

The letters were painted in white so bright they seemed to glare at the trees.

“Stop there!” a voice shouted from the crater. “The forest’s promised hero has arrived!”

Slotholumule raised his head. A human stood on a metal platform below, stern-faced and broad-shouldered, with a dark coat buttoned to the throat. Around him, robed cultists watched from trenches cut into the crater wall. Some carried staffs. Others held small silver boxes that clicked and flashed.

Swiftwing swooped low beside Slotholumule’s ear. “They were waiting for us.”

“Of course they were,” Thumper muttered. The rabbit’s ears pressed flat as another silver box turned toward them. “Half the ridge is watching.”

Stoneback planted his heavy feet in the dust. “Then let them watch us ask questions.”

Wiseclaw, perched on a twisted root, narrowed his eyes at the structures below.
“Questions are dangerous here. They have built answers before anyone can speak.”

Slotholumule touched the painted 4M FACE on his shirt. The cloth was dusty from the trail, but the letters remained clear. Fairness demanded more than courage. It demanded proof.

He stepped to the ridge edge.

“We came to learn what happens inside that crater,” he called. “If Flat Earth HQ protects the forest, show us how.”

The human smiled without warmth.

“I am the Cult Leader,” he said. “You already know enough. The earth is flat. The forest’s old records are lies. Every message, map, and warning has been shaped by those who fear the truth.”

“Truth does not need guards with weapons,” Slotholumule answered.

A murmur passed through the cultists. The Cult Leader lifted one hand, and the sound died.

“You wear a slogan and call it justice,” he said. “But slogans cannot stop what is coming.”

A burst of static snapped from the silver boxes. For one strange second, the wind vanished. Then every voice on the ridge - Swiftwing’s, Thumper’s, even Slotholumule’s own - spilled from the devices in a warped chorus.

“Turn back,” the boxes whispered.

Thumper flinched. “That was my voice.”

Slotholumule felt cold move beneath his fur. The cult had not merely been watching them. It had been listening.

He turned to Swiftwing. "Circle the crater. Find where those signals begin."

Swiftwing launched into the air. The wind returned with a sharp rush, carrying the smell of hot metal and sulfur. She flew along the rim, dipping toward the banner poles, then veering over a line of black cables that disappeared beneath the rock.

"There!" she cried. "The cables run into the eastern wall!"

A cultist fired. The dart struck the stone beside her wing and burst into blue sparks. Swiftwing twisted away, but the blast singed her feathers.

"Swiftwing!" Slotholumule shouted.

"I'm flying!" she called back, though her voice was strained.

Stoneback charged toward the nearest slope. "We can reach the cables."

"No," Wiseclaw said. "That is exactly where they want us."

A thin crack opened in the ground between them. The ridge shuddered. Dust rolled over their feet. Below, a gate slid open in the crater wall, revealing a tunnel lit by pulsing red lamps.

The Cult Leader spread his arms.

"Come and see," he called. "You want evidence. I will give you a path."

Slotholumule stared at the tunnel. The invitation was too easy, and the danger was obvious. Yet the cables vanished inside it. If he turned away, the cult would keep control of the story. Forest creatures would hear only the voices Flat Earth HQ chose to broadcast.

He took one step forward.

Thumper grabbed his sleeve. "That is a trap."

"Yes," Slotholumule said. "But it is also our first real lead."

Stoneback moved beside him. "Then we enter together."

The group descended the crater wall while cultists watched from above. Loose stones skittered beneath Slotholumule's claws. Heat breathed from the rock, carrying the bitter scent of oil. At the tunnel mouth, the red lamps flickered in time with a deep mechanical throb.

Inside, the walls were lined with glass tubes. Pale light streamed through them, filled with drifting sparks. Voices murmured from hidden speakers: market announcements, forest warnings, private conversations. Some recordings were clear. Others had been cut and spliced until familiar words sounded cruel.

Slotholumule stopped beside one speaker.

A badger's voice emerged from it.

"Slotholumule cannot protect anyone."

The recording ended. Another began.

"Fairness is weakness."

Thumper's whiskers trembled. "They're using the voices from the clearing."

"Not just using them," Wiseclaw said. He touched a cable with one claw, then pulled back as it vibrated. "They are changing them."

A door slammed behind the group.

Cultists poured into the tunnel.

Stoneback lowered his shell. "We have company."

The first attacker swung a staff. Stoneback caught it against his shell, and the impact rang through the passage. Thumper darted between the cultists' legs, kicking loose a power box. Sparks sprayed across the floor.

"Keep moving!" Slotholumule shouted.

He grabbed a hanging cable and pulled. The glass tubes burst one after another, releasing a storm of voices. The tunnel filled with cries, accusations, and pleas. The cultists staggered, covering their ears.

For a moment, Slotholumule heard the forest as it truly was: the market bell, children laughing near the creek, Perry the Possum arguing over a missing basket, Swiftwing calling warnings from the sky. Then the Cult Leader's voice cut through all of it.

"Enough!"

Every light turned white.

The Cult Leader stood at the far end of the tunnel, holding a black device shaped like a flattened stone. A ring of symbols glowed across its surface. The air tightened around it. Slotholumule's fur lifted.

"This is the Voice Engine," the Cult Leader said. "It reaches every communication post from the mountains to the southern marsh. With it, we can decide what the forest remembers."

"You mean you can lie to everyone at once," Slotholumule said.

"I mean I can prevent confusion."

"By erasing anyone who disagrees?"

The Cult Leader's expression hardened. "History belongs to those with the strength to preserve it."

Slotholumule glanced at the cables, the broken tubes, and the cultists closing in. The threat was no longer a rumor or a dart fired from the dark. Flat Earth HQ controlled a network capable of bending every message in the forest.

But the device in the Cult Leader's hands was not connected to the cables.

A missing link.

Slotholumule's eyes followed a thin red wire running from the wall toward a sealed iron door. The wire disappeared beneath it.

"Wiseclaw," he whispered. "What is behind that door?"

The owl studied the markings. "A relay chamber, perhaps. Or a dead end."

"Find out."

Wiseclaw flew toward the door, but a cultist hurled a metal hook. It caught his wing and dragged him down.

Slotholumule moved before thought could slow him. He lunged, seized the hook, and pulled with all his strength. The metal cut into his paw. Stoneback slammed into the cultist, freeing Wiseclaw, while Thumper tore the hook loose from the floor.

The iron door began to open.

A figure stood beyond it, wrapped in a gray cloak.

The stranger's face remained hidden, but their voice carried a tremor that was not fear. "You should not have come this far."

The Cult Leader's gaze snapped toward them.

"Ex-Member."

The cloaked figure froze.

Slotholumule stepped between them. "You know what this place does?"

"I helped build part of it," Ex-Member said. "I believed we were protecting the forest from false information. Then I saw the edits. They were not correcting lies. They were burying witnesses."

The Cult Leader raised the Voice Engine. "You ran because you lacked the courage to finish the work."

"I ran because creatures disappeared from the record," Ex-Member replied. "Their names. Their warnings. Their proof."

A sharp tone sounded from the device. Across the tunnel, the speakers crackled. The forest's emergency channel came alive.

The Cult Leader spoke into the air, his voice suddenly booming far beyond the crater.

"Slotholumule's Claw has attacked a peaceful truth center. They seek to silence the forest."

The message raced through the cables.

Slotholumule felt the cost of their discovery land like a stone in his stomach. They had found the source, but the cult had already turned the truth against them.

"Can you stop the broadcast?" he asked Ex-Member.

"Not from here."

"Then where?"

Ex-Member pointed through the iron doorway. Beyond it, a narrow stairway descended into darkness. "The central command is below. The Voice Engine is only the key. The main transmitter is deeper in the crater."

Another wave of static rolled through the tunnel. This time, Slotholumule heard his own voice twisted into a confession.

"I want power."

Thumper stared at him. "They're making you sound like the Cult Leader."

Slotholumule tightened his injured paw around the black-feathered dart. Pain sharpened his thoughts. The cult had been hiding its reach, but now its source stood before him - and beneath them waited something larger.

The Cult Leader stepped backward as steel shutters began closing between the tunnel and the stairway.

“By sunset,” he said, “every creature in the forest will believe you are the threat.”

Slotholumule looked at his team. Swiftwing’s singed feathers trembled. Stoneback’s shell was cracked along one edge. Wiseclaw’s wing bled where the hook had caught him. Thumper stood panting beside the broken power box.

They had earned proof.

It was worse than they feared.

“Into the stairway,” Slotholumule said.

The group rushed forward. Ex-Member seized the shutter controls and held them open as the metal descended. Slotholumule slipped beneath it, then turned back.

“Come on!”

Ex-Member’s hand shook against the lever. “I will follow.”

The shutter slammed down.

Slotholumule struck the metal with both paws. “Ex-Member!”

From the other side came a burst of shouting, then the hard crack of the Voice Engine.

The stairway plunged beneath the crater. Above, the Cult Leader’s broadcast continued to spread through the forest, smooth and certain and false.

Slotholumule faced the darkness below.

They had found the cult's hand.

Now they had to reach its heart before the lie became everyone's truth.

CHAPTER 4

Unity Beats the Lies

The cult's hand had been found, but its fingers were already closing around the forest.

Slotholumule pressed one paw against the rough bark of a fallen log while the other held down the corner of a crude map. Damp moss curled beneath his claws. The clearing smelled of wet leaves and crushed fern, and somewhere beyond the trees, a warning bell rang once before going silent. He could not stop thinking about the Voice Engine beneath Flat Earth HQ. If the Cult Leader reached every burrow, nest, and village through that machine, truth would no longer need to be proven. It would simply be repeated until no one remembered asking who had been harmed.

"We need a team," he said.

The words sounded small beneath the dripping branches. The decision did not.

Thumper arrived first, bounding through the ferns with mud on her paws and a torn strip of red cloth tied around one ear. "A team for what?"

Slotholumule turned the map toward her. Its lines were scratched in charcoal across a sheet of bark. A black circle marked the crater. Three crooked paths led toward it, though none showed what waited beyond the rim.

"To enter the crater," he said. "To find the Voice Engine and stop the broadcast before it spreads."

Thumper's ears lifted, then flattened. "You said that place was guarded."

"It is."

"And the tunnels go deeper than the iron door."

"Yes."

She stared at him. "That is a poor beginning to a plan."

"It is the truth," Slotholumule answered. The painted 4M FACE on his shirt was stained from the northern trail, but the letters still showed through. "We begin with the truth."

A rush of wings cut through the clearing. Swiftwing landed on a low branch, scattering beads of water. "Then begin with a map that isn't trying to kill us."

She dropped a bundle of leaves beside the bark sheet. Inside were scraps of bark, feathers, and a thin metal plate stamped with the cult's white-circle symbol.

"I circled the crater from above," Swiftwing said. "The north face has watchtowers. The west face is steep enough to break a climber's neck. The south side looks open, which means it is probably a trap."

"Probably?" Thumper asked.

Swiftwing clicked her beak. "The cult has hidden wires between the rocks. I saw them flash when one of their patrols crossed the slope."

Stoneback pushed through the brush behind her. The turtle carried a coil of vine over his shell and a stone mallet in his mouth. He set both down with a heavy thump.

"I can deal with the wires," he said. "Not quickly. Not quietly. But I can deal with them."

Wiseclaw followed at a measured pace, his old eyes fixed on the map. "The crater is not only a hole in the ground. It is a fortress built around a message."

Slotholumule looked at him. "What do you mean?"

"The paths are arranged to guide travelers toward the towers." Wiseclaw tapped the bark with one claw. "The cult wants anyone approaching to be seen, counted, and frightened. The terrain is part of their argument. They make the world feel narrow, watched, and already decided."

A fox slipped from between two trees, red fur darkened by rain. Roost carried a bundle of stolen keys in his teeth. He dropped them beside the map.

"I found these under a guard's cloak," he said. "The lock on the old drainage gate uses the long iron key. The short one opens a supply tunnel."

Thumper sniffed the keys. "You stole them?"

"Borrowed them from a guard who won't need them for a while."

"Roost."

"He was asleep."

Wiseclaw's gaze sharpened. "And the guard?"

"Still asleep."

Slotholumule studied the four animals gathered around the map. A rabbit who moved faster than fear could catch her. A bird who could see the crater's defenses. A turtle who could endure what others could not. A fox who knew how to slip through places meant to keep everyone out. They were not alike, and that was precisely why the cult would struggle to predict them.

Still, the map was too thin. Its southern edge ended in a ragged tear. The western route vanished beneath a smear of rain.

"Where is the rest?" Slotholumule asked.

Roost's ears angled back. "There was more. I saw a second map in the guard post."

"Then we take it."

A low mechanical hum rolled through the forest.

Every animal froze.

The sound came from beyond the clearing, faint at first, then stronger. Leaves trembled on their stems. The metal plate beside the map began to vibrate.

Swiftwing launched into the air. "They're broadcasting."

A voice spilled from the trees, smooth and stern.

"Forest creatures, remain where you are. Flat Earth HQ protects you from confusion. Those who spread false questions serve chaos."

Thumper's fur rose along her spine. The voice was not coming from one throat. It echoed from hidden speakers, each repetition arriving a breath apart.

Slotholumule felt the clearing tighten around them. The words pushed against old fears: the fear of being watched, the fear of standing alone, the fear that fairness was only a promise until someone stronger demanded silence.

Stoneback leaned toward the map. "We should move."

"If we run, they know we are here," Wiseclaw said.

"If we stay, they surround us," Roost replied.

The voice continued. "Your leaders have failed you. Their slogans cannot feed you. Their questions cannot shelter you. Follow the marked paths, and order will be restored."

Slotholumule looked down at the 4M FACE painted across his shirt. He remembered the cracked market wheel, the animals forced to wait while others took what they wanted, and the cult dart closed in his paw. The cult did not need every creature to believe its story. It only needed them to believe no one could challenge it.

He placed both paws on the map.

"Swiftwing, find the speakers," he said. "Do not attack. Mark their positions."

She dipped one wing and rose through the dripping canopy.

"Stoneback, take the drainage gate. If the cult patrols come, make them choose between following you and guarding the crater."

Stoneback's jaw tightened. "I can make that choice unpleasant."

"Roost, get us the missing map."

Roost gave a sharp grin. "That part I understand."

"Thumper, stay with me."

She nodded, though her hind legs quivered.

Wiseclaw watched Slotholumule. "And your task?"

Slotholumule rolled the bark map carefully and tucked it beneath his shirt. "I will keep us together."

The first cultist burst into the clearing before anyone could move. A black mask covered his face, and a white circle had been painted across his chest. Behind him came two more, carrying hooked staffs. The broadcast voice crackled overhead.

"Step away from the map."

Thumper sprang forward. The nearest staff swept through the space where her head had been. She twisted, kicked the cultist's knee, and darted behind Stoneback.

Stoneback drove his shell into the second guard. The impact knocked the guard into a tree with a grunt. Roost snatched the third guard's cloak and yanked him backward into the mud.

Slotholumule did not strike. He seized the staff as it came around again, letting its hook catch his sleeve. The cultist pulled hard. Slotholumule used the force to swing

himself beneath the guard's arm, then planted both feet against the guard's chest and shoved. The mask flew loose.

The guard stared at him, young and frightened.

"You heard the broadcast," Slotholumule said. "Did it tell you to protect the forest, or to protect the people who control the machine?"

The guard's grip weakened.

A sharp whistle cut through the clearing. Swiftwing circled above the eastern trees.

"Three speakers," she called. "One in the hollow trunk, two beneath the roots. Patrols are coming from the north."

"Then we go south," Slotholumule said.

They ran.

The southern route dropped between leaning trees and slick black stones. Rainwater rushed beneath their feet, carrying splinters and leaves toward the crater. Thumper slipped once, and Slotholumule caught her by the shoulder before she fell into a narrow trench lined with metal teeth.

"That was not on the map," she gasped.

"Neither was the trench," he said.

"That is becoming a pattern."

Behind them, the broadcast changed. The Cult Leader's voice grew louder, stripped of its calm.

"Do not trust the sloth. He will lead you into danger."

Slotholumule felt the words strike harder than any staff. Thumper glanced at him.

"Are you going to answer that?"

He looked toward the crater. Above its rim, the Flat Earth HQ banner snapped in the wind, bright against the gray sky.

"No," he said. "We answer by reaching the gate."

At the base of the southern slope, they found a wall of fallen stone blocking the path. The crater's outer defenses had collapsed there, but the gap was too narrow for Stoneback and too high for Thumper to jump.

Roost examined the rocks. "We need another route."

A shadow moved beyond the wall.

The cloaked Ex-Member stepped into view, face hidden beneath a wet hood. The group turned as one. Stoneback lowered his head. Thumper bared her teeth.

"You followed us," Roost said.

"I followed the broadcast," Ex-Member replied. "The cult has sealed the eastern tunnels. They know someone is moving against the Voice Engine."

Slotholumule held his ground. "How do we enter?"

Ex-Member pointed toward the broken wall. "There is a maintenance shaft beneath the stones. It leads to the old drainage gate, but the route is missing from every map the cult gives its recruits."

"Why tell us now?" Wiseclaw asked.

"Because the Cult Leader has begun the first wide transmission." Ex-Member's voice trembled beneath the hood. "If he completes it, every communication line in the forest will carry his version of the truth."

The machine hummed again. Far above, hidden speakers awakened one after another.

Thumper pressed close to Slotholumule. "We cannot wait for a better map."

"No," he said. He looked at each member of the team. "We go through the shaft."

Stoneback wedged his shell beneath the largest fallen slab. Muscles strained across his neck. "On your signal."

Slotholumule placed a paw against the stone beside him. "Together."

Stoneback pushed. Slotholumule shoved with him. Thumper dug her paws into the mud and added her strength. Roost pulled at a jutting root, while Swiftwing beat her wings against the loose debris from above. The slab shifted with a grinding roar.

A dark opening appeared beneath it.

Then the rest of the wall collapsed.

Stoneback disappeared beneath the stones.

"Stoneback!" Thumper cried.

Slotholumule clawed at the rubble until sharp rock tore his sleeve. Roost joined him. Swiftwing landed and pecked at smaller stones. At last Stoneback's head emerged, dusty and bleeding above one eye.

"I am here," he said.

"But the shaft is blocked," Wiseclaw warned.

The opening had vanished beneath the collapse. The only visible path now led back toward the north, where cult voices multiplied between the trees.

Ex-Member pointed toward a narrow crack in the crater wall. "There is another entrance. It opens into the supply tunnel."

"Is it on the map?" Slotholumule asked.

“No.”

A distant siren began to howl. The ground shuddered beneath their feet.

Slotholumule pulled the ruined map from beneath his shirt. Mud had blurred the charcoal lines. The route they had chosen was gone, and the remaining paths ended before the crater’s heart.

He folded the map and looked at his team.

“We still enter,” he said.

Thumper swallowed her fear. “Even without the route?”

“Especially without it. The cult built those paths to separate us.”

Stoneback hauled himself free of the rubble. “Then we stay close.”

Swiftwing rose to scout the crack. Roost gathered the keys. Wiseclaw moved beside Slotholumule, and Ex-Member turned toward the hidden entrance.

Behind them, the forest speakers carried the Cult Leader’s lie from branch to branch.

Ahead, the crater opened like a wound in the earth.

Slotholumule stepped into the narrow darkness first. One by one, the others followed, shoulder to shoulder, while the missing routes waited somewhere beneath Flat Earth HQ.

CHAPTER 5

Crossing Rivers, Climbing Mountains

Rain hammered the mountain pass hard enough to blur the trail into silver ropes. Swiftwing fought the wind above the river, wings shuddering as the storm-swollen current tore through the gorge below.

“There!” she called, banking toward a shelf of black stone. “The bank is narrower past the bend. We can cross there.”

A flash of lightning revealed the others climbing behind her. Slotholumule moved slowly but steadily, his 4M FACE shirt dark with rain. Thumper clung to a root beside him. Stoneback hauled himself up the slope with Wiseclaw close behind, while Roost and Perry picked their way through the dripping brush.

Swiftwing landed on the shelf and folded her wings against the cold. The river roared beneath it, brown water smashing against boulders and dragging whole branches into the gorge.

They had left the crater’s tunnels behind for the moment, following the route hidden in the Ex-Member’s map. The path toward the deeper entrance crossed the mountains, then the river, then a forest thick enough to swallow a marching line. Swiftwing’s task was clear: find a safe way forward and keep the team moving.

But the river had erased every safe way she could see.

Slotholumule reached the shelf and looked down. “Can we cross?”

“Not here,” Swiftwing said.

Thumper wiped rain from his whiskers. "You said the bend was better."

"It was better yesterday."

Stoneback gave a low rumble. "The mountain disagrees."

Another crack split the air. A section of the far bank collapsed into the torrent. Mud and stones vanished beneath the water.

Swiftwing stared at the gap. Her feathers prickled with rain. From above, she could scout farther than any of them. She could spot a fallen tree, a ledge, a break in the forest. That was why Slotholumule had trusted her with the lead.

Trust. The word felt heavier than the wet air.

She had promised to keep them safe, yet every route she found ended in a worse danger. The southern trail had vanished beneath a landslide. The mountain path had narrowed to a ledge where one wrong step meant a long fall. Now the river raged between them and the crater.

"We turn back," Wiseclaw said. "The storm is making the crossing impossible."

Slotholumule shook his head. "Turning back takes us toward the patrol routes."

Swiftwing looked at him. "You heard the broadcast too?"

A faint metallic voice drifted through the rain from somewhere beyond the ridge.

"Flat Earth HQ protects the forest. Travelers who reject the truth endanger everyone."

The words broke apart in static, then returned louder.

"Report unauthorized movement."

Perry's ears flattened. "That sounds close."

Roost rose into the air, circling beneath the low clouds. He returned almost at once. "Two lights on the eastern ridge. Maybe three. They're moving toward us."

The cult had patrols in the mountains.

Swiftwing's stomach tightened. The river was dangerous, but the patrols would be worse. If they were caught, the cult could seize the map and learn about the hidden routes.

"We cross," Swiftwing said.

Wiseclaw's eyes narrowed. "That was not the safe choice."

"It is the only choice that keeps us ahead."

Slotholumule studied the river, then the dark ridge. "What do you see?"

"A fallen pine caught between the rocks downstream. Its trunk reaches the far bank, but the current is eating through it."

"Can it hold Stoneback?"

Stoneback snorted. "Ask whether Stoneback can hold it."

Thumper pointed toward the gorge. "The tree is already twisting."

Swiftwing lifted her wings. "I can guide the crossing from above. Thumper goes first with a rope. Stoneback anchors it. The rest follow one at a time."

"And you?" Slotholumule asked.

"I'll watch the ridge."

His gaze stayed on her. "No. You cross with us."

"I can see the patrols from the air."

"You can see them after we reach the other side."

The rain ran from his face, but his voice remained calm. That calm irritated her more than an order would have. He had never asked her to be less useful. He was asking her to be present.

"I am useful in the air," she said.

"You are part of this team on the ground."

The words struck deeper than the cold. Swiftwing glanced toward the ridge. Three pale lights slid between the trees.

"Fine," she said. "But if the trunk breaks, I leave the rope and fly."

"Fair," Slotholumule replied. "That is your choice to make."

Thumper tied the rope around his waist and edged onto the slick shelf. Stoneback braced himself behind him, claws digging into mud. The fallen pine groaned as Thumper stepped onto it.

Water sprayed high enough to soak his face. He crouched, gripping the rope with both paws.

"Keep moving," Swiftwing called.

"I am moving!"

The trunk rolled beneath him. Thumper yelped and dropped flat. Stoneback pulled the rope tight, stopping him from sliding into the river.

Swiftwing launched herself into the storm. Wind shoved her sideways, but she fought toward the ridge. The patrol lights had stopped. Beneath them, dark figures stood among the trees.

One raised something long and narrow.

A cult dart flashed through the rain.

Swiftwing twisted. The dart sliced through her tail feathers and disappeared into the clouds.

"They've seen us!" she shouted.

Below, Slotholumule stepped onto the tree.

"Move!" Swiftwing cried. "Now!"

The patrols began descending the ridge.

Thumper crawled forward. Stoneback followed, each step testing the trembling trunk. Slotholumule moved behind them, his claws gripping the wet bark. Wiseclaw and Perry waited on the near bank, while Roost flew low over the river, shouting directions through the thunder.

"Left! The bark is splitting on the right!"

Slotholumule shifted left. The pine lurched.

Swiftwing dove toward the far bank. She saw a strip of rope caught around a crooked branch, its loose end trailing into the current. If it pulled free, the crossing line would vanish.

She landed hard, seized the rope in her beak, and dragged it around the branch. The fibers burned against her tongue. Behind her, Thumper reached the far side and pulled. The rope tightened.

"Stoneback!" Slotholumule called.

The turtle was halfway across when the pine cracked.

For one breath, the whole tree hung over the river.

Then the trunk split.

Stoneback dropped, claws scraping bark. Slotholumule lunged and caught the rope. The sudden weight yanked him forward. His body slammed against the pine as the broken half swung downstream.

"Hold!" Stoneback roared.

Swiftwing dug her talons into the mud and pulled with everything she had. Thumper seized the rope beside her. On the opposite bank, Perry and Wiseclaw added their weight.

Stoneback's shell struck the water. The current spun him toward the rocks.

"Stoneback!" Thumper screamed.

Swiftwing saw the angle before anyone else. The rope would not pull him up in time. A branch jutted from the broken trunk, pointing toward the far bank.

She released the rope.

"Swiftwing!" Slotholumule shouted.

She plunged into the rain, seized Stoneback's foreleg, and beat her wings against the gale. The turtle was far too heavy to lift, but she did not need to lift him. She needed to turn him.

The current slammed them both against the branch. Pain flashed through her wing. Stoneback hooked one claw around the wood.

"Pull!" Swiftwing cried.

The team hauled. Stoneback crawled up the branch, inch by inch, until Thumper grabbed his shell and dragged him onto solid ground.

Swiftwing flapped toward the bank, but her injured wing buckled. She struck the mud and rolled.

Slotholumule reached her. "Can you fly?"

"Not well."

"Then we walk."

The patrols had reached the near shelf. Voices shouted through the rain. A black-feathered dart struck the mud beside Slotholumule's paw.

He looked at it, then at Swiftwing's torn feathers.

"No one gets left behind," he said.

They ran.

The far bank opened into dense forest. Vines slapped their faces, wet leaves hid holes in the ground, and the smell of crushed fern filled the air. Swiftwing moved at the front despite her wing, using her beak and talons to mark branches for the others. Behind them, the patrols crashed through the undergrowth.

The forest forced them into a narrow ravine. At its end stood a wall of stone, smooth and impossible.

"We're trapped," Perry whispered.

Swiftwing pressed her wing against the rock. Cold seeped through her feathers. She had led them into another dead end.

Slotholumule approached, breathing hard. "What do you need?"

"A path."

"That is not an answer."

She closed her eyes. Rain tapped the leaves overhead. Beneath it came another sound: a hollow rush, as if water moved inside the mountain.

Swiftwing opened her eyes and looked at the wall. A thin line of moss bent inward.

"There," she said. "The rock is split."

Stoneback wedged his claws into the seam. Thumper pushed beside him. The stone shifted just enough to reveal a cramped passage.

The patrol voices grew louder.

"Everyone through," Slotholumule said.

Swiftwing entered last. The gap closed behind her with a grinding thud. Darkness swallowed the team. For several moments, only their breathing and the distant pounding of the river filled the passage.

Then a pale opening appeared ahead.

They emerged onto a high shelf above the forest.

Beyond the trees, the land dropped away.

The crater spread across the valley, vast and raw, its walls ringed with floodlights. Above it snapped the banner: FLAT EARTH HQ. Patrols moved along the rim, their lanterns sweeping the slopes. Metal towers rose from the crater's depths, carrying the Voice Engine's signal into the storm.

Swiftwing forgot the pain in her wing.

They had reached the edge.

Thumper crouched beside a boulder. "We made it."

Stoneback looked back toward the hidden passage. "And the patrols?"

A lantern beam crossed the forest below.

"They found the ravine," Roost said.

Wiseclaw's voice was quiet. "Stealth is gone."

Slotholumule studied the crater. The lights moved in patterns, sealing every approach. The team had crossed the river, climbed the mountain, and forced a path through the forest. They had earned their arrival.

But the crater was waiting for them in full view.

Swiftwing folded her damaged wing against her side. "I can draw the patrols away."

"No," Slotholumule said.

"I can still fly."

"And they can still shoot."

A second beam swept across the ridge. Somewhere below, a horn sounded.

Slotholumule looked at each of them, then at the towering lights around Flat Earth HQ.

"We cannot enter unseen," he said. "So we stop trying to be unseen."

Swiftwing felt the team shift beside her. Fear remained, but none of them stepped back.

From the crater, the Cult Leader's voice rolled over the valley through hidden speakers.

"Come forward, defenders. Let the forest watch you fail."

Slotholumule's paw closed around the black-feathered dart he had carried from the riverbank.

Swiftwing raised her beak toward the floodlights. "Then let the forest watch us arrive."

Together, they stepped onto the ridge, with the crater blazing below and every patrol turning toward them.

CHAPTER 6

The Crater Edge Standoff

The floodlights struck Stoneback's shell so hard that every old scratch shone white. Below him, the crater boiled with movement. Patrols poured between metal barricades, boots and claws striking the rock in a hard, rising rhythm, while the Flat Earth HQ banner snapped above the pit like a torn piece of night.

"Down!" Stoneback shouted.

A black-feathered dart hissed past his cheek and struck the ridge behind him. Its white-circle mark flashed in the light.

Stoneback lowered himself, planting all four feet against the damp stone. The ridge trembled beneath the patrols' charge. Somewhere behind him, Swiftwing beat her wings once, twice, trying to lift clear of the floodlights. Thumper dragged Wiseclaw behind a slab of basalt. Roost's claws scraped for a hold.

Slotholumule remained at the front.

His shirt, painted with the words 4M FACE, gleamed beneath his fur. He stared down into the crater, slow and steady despite the alarm bells ringing from the walls.

"Give me ten breaths," he said.

Stoneback looked at him. "Ten?"

"Ten."

The order was impossible. That was why Stoneback moved.

He rose from cover and slammed his shell against the ridge's narrowest path. Stone cracked under the impact. Loose gravel spilled toward the crater, forcing the first line of cultists to stumble and bunch together.

"Back!" shouted a cult guard.

"Not yet," Stoneback growled.

A second dart struck his shell with a sharp click. Another bounced off and spun into the darkness. The cold metal stung through the plates, but he held his ground.

Thumper sprang beside him, ears flat. "They're circling left!"

"I see them."

"No, you don't." Wiseclaw's voice came from behind the basalt. "Three squads. The left one is carrying a net."

Stoneback glanced toward the floodlights. A mesh of dark cable stretched between two cultists as they advanced along the rim. Behind them came more patrols, faces hidden beneath white masks marked with circles.

"Then break their line," Stoneback said.

Thumper's foot struck the ground. A stone the size of a melon shot downhill and smashed into the net carriers. One fell. The other released the mesh, which snapped through the air and wrapped around a floodlight post.

For half a breath, the ridge darkened.

Stoneback heard Swiftwing cry, "Now!"

She dropped from above, wings slicing the nearest guard's mask away. The guard reeled. Roost darted in and clawed the weapon from his hand before vanishing behind a jut of rock.

The team had made space.

Stoneback turned toward Slotholumule. "Eight breaths."

Slotholumule had not moved. His gaze traveled from the barricades to the iron doors below, then to the towers bristling with antennae. Blue pulses jumped between metal dishes. Each pulse made the air vibrate against Stoneback's shell.

"The Voice Engine is shielded," Slotholumule said. "The power lines run beneath the western wall. The central command is deeper than we thought."

A man stepped onto the highest platform in the crater.

The cultists fell silent.

He wore a dark coat buttoned to the throat. His hair was silver at the temples, and his expression held no anger, only the hard patience of someone accustomed to being obeyed. The Cult Leader rested one hand on a metal console beside him.

"Slotholumule," he called. His voice rolled across the crater without effort. "You crossed mountains, rivers, and half the forest to stand on a ledge."

Stoneback tightened his stance.

The Cult Leader's eyes moved over the group. "A bird. A rabbit. A fox. A turtle. A possum. A wise old creature hiding behind stone. You call this an army?"

"We call it an alliance," Slotholumule answered.

A murmur moved through the patrols.

The Cult Leader smiled without warmth. "An alliance is merely a crowd waiting to be frightened apart."

He touched the console.

The antennas screamed.

Stoneback's vision blurred. The rock beneath his feet seemed to tilt, and voices burst from hidden speakers around the crater. They overlapped in dozens of tones - forest warnings, market announcements, pleas for help, familiar songs twisted into commands.

"Leave the ridge," one voice said.

"Slotholumule has abandoned you," said another.

"Stoneback is too slow to protect anyone."

Stoneback clenched his jaw. The words were false, but they carried the voices of creatures he knew. He heard the cracked market bell from the clearing. He heard frightened animals calling for fairness, then heard the same voices turn against the team.

Thumper staggered. "That's not real!"

"It doesn't have to be," Wiseclaw said. "It only has to sound real."

The Cult Leader lifted his voice over the noise. "Truth is whatever reaches the most ears. History is whatever survives the telling. With the Voice Engine, every forest, every town, every record can carry our version first."

Slotholumule's claws curled.

The Cult Leader continued, "We will erase the protests. The broken carts. The hungry nests. The names of those denied shelter and work. We will replace them with obedience. Future generations will remember that the forest was peaceful because we commanded it to be."

Stoneback felt the ridge beneath him, solid and cold. He thought of the market cart overturned in the clearing, its cracked wheel ignored while creatures were told that neglect was natural. He thought of Slotholumule standing there in the painted 4M FACE shirt, refusing to let a lie become law.

"You can rewrite a message," Slotholumule said, "but you cannot rewrite what people lived."

The Cult Leader's expression hardened. "People live what they are told to remember."

He struck the console again.

The crater wall opened.

Panels of black metal unfolded from the rock, revealing rows of devices aimed at the ridge. Their lenses glowed red. Stoneback recognized the shape of the cult's darts before the first volley fired.

"Hold!" he roared.

He lunged sideways, shell first. The darts struck him in a storm of clicks. One pierced the edge of his shell. Pain flashed through his body, hot and sudden, but his weight drove into the nearest weapon mount. Metal buckled. The device spat sparks and went dark.

Thumper and Roost attacked the next mount together. Swiftwing blinded its lens with a torn strip of banner. Wiseclaw shouted directions through the electronic shriek.

"Right side! Two more!"

Stoneback tried to turn.

A cable whipped around his rear leg.

He fell hard. His shell slammed the stone, knocking the breath from him. Cultists surged forward, dragging the cable toward the crater stairs.

"Stoneback!" Thumper shouted.

Stoneback dug his claws into the ridge. The cable tightened. Behind him, the patrols were closing around the others.

"Go!" he rasped.

Slotholumule moved toward him.

"No," Stoneback said. "Look at the defenses!"

Slotholumule stopped.

For an instant, Stoneback saw the struggle in his face. The leader wanted to save him. The leader also knew that the crater's pattern was opening before them - the weapon mounts, the power lines, the hidden stairs. If Slotholumule stayed, the whole team might be trapped.

"Ten breaths," Stoneback reminded him.

Slotholumule's eyes sharpened.

He turned toward the western wall.

"Swiftwing, take the tower lights. Thumper, with me. Wiseclaw, find the cable release. Roost, get the others off the ridge."

Stoneback bared his teeth and pulled against the cable. "And me?"

"You keep them busy."

"That part I can do."

Slotholumule charged.

He moved slowly compared with the others, but every step carried purpose. Thumper bounded ahead, striking a guard beneath the knee. Slotholumule seized the fallen guard's shield and drove it into a weapon mount. The red lens shattered.

Swiftwing rose into the floodlights. Her wings flashed silver as she tore through the cables feeding them. One tower went black. Then another.

The false voices faltered.

Stoneback twisted his body and dragged two cultists off balance. One crashed against his shell. The other dropped the cable release tool. Stoneback could not reach it, but Roost streaked past, seized the tool, and flung it toward Wiseclaw.

Wiseclaw caught it in his beak.

The cable loosened.

Stoneback rolled free just as the ridge exploded beneath him.

A hidden charge hurled rock into the air. Stoneback struck the ground on his side. Dust filled his eyes. For several seconds he could hear nothing but a deep ringing.

Then Thumper's voice broke through. "Stoneback! Move!"

Stoneback pushed himself upright. The ridge had split between the team and the crater stairs. A jagged gap yawned where the path had been. On the far side, Slotholumule stood alone, surrounded by cultists.

The Cult Leader watched from his platform.

"You see?" he called. "This crater answers to me. Every stone, every signal, every path. I decide who enters and who leaves."

Slotholumule raised the stolen shield. "You're afraid of what's beneath it."

The Cult Leader's hand hovered over the console.

"Capture him."

The patrols surged.

Slotholumule struck the nearest guard aside, but three more closed in. Swiftwing dove, raking at their masks. Thumper leapt across the broken ridge and slammed into a cultist's chest. The impact sent both of them tumbling toward the gap.

Stoneback caught Thumper by one ear.

“Got you!”

Thumper swung against the stone, kicking free of the cultist’s grasp. Stoneback hauled him back, but the delay cost them. More patrols flooded the ridge, shields locked together.

“Back to the trees!” Wiseclaw ordered.

Slotholumule looked once toward the iron doors. The blue pulse of the Voice Engine beat behind them, steady as a mechanical heart.

Then he lowered the shield.

“Fall back!”

Stoneback hated the command, but he obeyed. He rammed the nearest shield line, opening a narrow passage. Roost slipped through first. Wiseclaw followed. Thumper bounded after him. Swiftwing dropped low enough for Stoneback to grasp her leg, and she hauled him across the broken stone as the patrols thrust forward.

Slotholumule came last.

A dart struck his shoulder.

Stoneback saw him flinch. The black feather trembled against his fur, its white circle bright beneath the floodlights.

“Slotholumule!” Stoneback shouted.

The sloth snapped the dart free and kept moving.

They reached the ridge’s dark side, where wet roots clawed through the soil. Stoneback shoved the others down the slope. Rocks chased them through the brush. Behind them, alarms rang across the crater, and the Cult Leader’s voice followed over every speaker.

“Run back to your forest,” he declared. “Tell them the crater belongs to Flat Earth HQ. Tell them history has already chosen its authors.”

Stoneback landed against a tree trunk. Pain throbbed through his shell and leg. Thumper crouched beside him, breathing hard. Swiftwing’s feathers were torn at the tips. Wiseclaw’s tool lay bent in the mud.

Slotholumule reached them last, one paw pressed over the dart wound.

The crater blazed above the trees.

The Cult Leader appeared at the rim, small from this distance but unmistakable, framed by the snapping Flat Earth HQ banner.

“I control the crater!” he shouted.

The Voice Engine carried the boast into the forest, repeating it until the words seemed to come from every direction.

Stoneback looked at Slotholumule. They had held the line. They had learned where the defenses ran. They had also lost the ridge, the route, and their chance to reach the iron doors unseen.

Slotholumule pulled the painted shirt straight across his chest.

“Then we take back the ground he thinks belongs to him,” he said.

Above them, the crater lights swept through the trees.

And somewhere beneath the rock, the Voice Engine began broadcasting a new version of their retreat.

CHAPTER 7



Tunnels Under Flat Earth HQ

Thumper hit the ground behind a slab of black stone as a floodlight skimmed the crater rim. Dust burst beneath his paws. Above, the Voice Engine twisted their retreat into a lie, its cold broadcast rolling through the rock.

“Keep low,” Slotholumule whispered.

Thumper flattened himself beside him, ears pinned back. The air smelled of hot metal and scorched soil. Somewhere beyond the stone, boots scraped over gravel. A patrol shouted that the intruders were fleeing south.

“We are fleeing,” Thumper breathed. “Just not where they think.”

Swiftwing dropped from a ledge and folded her wings tight. Stoneback followed, his shell dragging against the rock with a dull scrape. Wiseclaw and Roost slipped from the brush. The Ex-Member emerged last, cloak torn at one shoulder, one hand pressed against a fresh cut.

The broadcast changed again.

“Flat Earth HQ has secured the crater. The trespassers have been scattered. No threat remains.”

Thumper’s whiskers twitched. “That voice is coming from below.”

Slotholumule looked toward the crater wall. “Then below is where we go.”

They had reached the rim expecting guards, towers, and locked gates. They had found all three. The outer defenses had driven them back, but the retreat had revealed

something stranger: each time the Voice Engine spoke, a faint tremor passed through the stone beneath their feet. Thumper had felt it through his paws. Not an echo. A route.

He pressed one paw against the wall.

The rock hummed.

"This way," he said.

Roost glanced at the narrow ledge disappearing into darkness. "That is not a way. That is a crack."

"A crack with air moving through it."

"Air moves through plenty of cracks," Wiseclaw said. "Most of them lead nowhere."

Thumper crouched and sniffed. Beneath the dust and mineral stink lay oil, warm copper, and something sharp that made his nose sting. He scraped at the ground. A thin groove ran from the wall toward the crater floor, almost hidden beneath loose shale.

"The sound travels along this," he said. "The broadcast is being carried through the rock."

Slotholumule touched the groove, then turned to the Ex-Member. "You knew about tunnels."

The cloaked figure's face remained hidden. "I knew there were service passages. The Cult Leader never trusted the surface. He built beneath it."

"Why did you leave them?" Thumper asked.

The Ex-Member paused. "Because I learned what they planned to do with every voice they captured."

A patrol beam swept across the upper stones. The team pressed into the wall. Thumper felt the heat of Slotholumule's shoulder beside him and heard Stoneback's slow, careful breathing.

The light passed.

Thumper pointed to the crack. "We go now."

He squeezed through first. The stone scraped his back and caught at his fur. For three heartbeats there was only darkness, dust, and the thud of his own breath. Then the passage widened around him.

"Clear," he called softly.

One by one, the others entered. Stoneback had to turn sideways. Swiftwing tucked her wings against her body. Slotholumule came last, pulling a loose stone into place behind them.

The tunnel sloped downward.

A thin blue glow pulsed beneath their paws.

Thumper followed it, nose close to the ground. The passage forked after a dozen steps. One branch smelled of damp earth. The other carried hot metal and the faint vibration of machinery.

"The left one is natural," Wiseclaw murmured. "The right was cut."

Thumper studied the walls. Tiny white circles had been painted at ankle height, each one pointing toward the right-hand passage.

"The cult marked the route," he said.

"Or marked a trap," Roost replied.

Thumper's ears lifted. From the right passage came a soft clicking sound.

He raised a paw. Everyone froze.

Click. Click. Click.

A black-feathered dart shot from the wall and buried itself in the stone beside Thumper's head. Its white circle gleamed in the blue light.

Thumper stared at it. "Trap."

Stoneback moved in front of him. "You nearly lost an ear."

"Nearly is not lost."

"That is not the point," Slotholumule said.

Thumper examined the dart's angle. Another hole waited on the opposite wall. The clicking came from a row of narrow slots ahead.

"The marks show the safe path," he said. "But the path shifts."

"How do you know?" Swiftwing asked.

Thumper pointed to the floor. Dust lay thick along the left edge and thin along the right. Something had brushed the center recently. "Someone walked through. The darts fire when weight crosses the middle."

Roost's tail bristled. "Then how do we cross?"

Thumper looked at the ceiling. A rusted pipe ran above the passage, held by cracked brackets. He reached up and tugged. The pipe groaned.

"Not that," Wiseclaw warned.

Thumper tugged again. The pipe tore loose with a shriek.

Darts snapped from both walls.

He shoved the pipe across the passage. The darts struck metal in a frantic burst, clanging like hail. When the mechanism fell silent, Thumper bounded along the left edge, followed by Swiftwing and Roost. Stoneback crawled beneath the pipe. Slotholumule paused beside Thumper.

"You could have waited for a safer plan," the sloth said.

"There was a safer plan," Thumper replied. "It was on the other side of the darts."

For the first time since the standoff, Slotholumule smiled. Then the floor dropped beneath them.

Thumper landed hard on a metal platform. The others crashed down around him. A red light flickered overhead, painting the tunnel in pulses. The door behind them slammed shut.

A voice spoke through hidden speakers.

"Unauthorized movement detected."

The Cult Leader.

Thumper sprang toward the nearest panel. Wires trembled behind a glass cover. "He knows we're here."

"He knew before we entered," the Ex-Member said. "The tunnels listen."

A hiss filled the chamber. White vapor spilled from vents along the walls.

"Move!" Slotholumule shouted.

Thumper rammed his shoulder into a side hatch. It resisted. The vapor thickened, bitter on his tongue. Swiftwing beat her wings, driving the cloud back for a moment. Roost clawed at the hatch seam. Stoneback wedged his shell beneath the bottom edge.

"Together!" Slotholumule called.

Thumper dug in. His paws slipped on the metal. The hatch lifted a finger's width, then slammed down.

Again.

The vapor burned his eyes. He thought of the market cart wheel, cracked and abandoned while creatures were told their troubles did not matter. He thought of the Cult Leader's voice rewriting their retreat before their feet had even left the rim.

"Again!" he shouted.

Stoneback heaved. Roost pulled. Thumper pushed with everything in him. The hatch burst open, and cold air rushed through.

They tumbled into a narrow maintenance shaft. The door crashed shut behind them, trapping the white vapor on the other side.

Thumper lay on his back, coughing. Slotholumule's hand rested between his shoulders until his breathing steadied.

"You found the door," Slotholumule said.

"I found a door that wanted us dead."

"Still counts."

The shaft opened into a cavern large enough to swallow the forest market. Thumper crept to the edge and looked down.

Rows of machines filled the underground base. Copper cables hung in thick bundles from the ceiling. Glass tubes carried flickering bands of light through the walls. Great metal drums turned without touching the floor, their surfaces covered in maps, symbols, and moving lines.

At the center stood the Voice Engine.

It was not one machine but a tower of black metal rings surrounding a column of white fire. Every pulse sent a tremor through the cavern. The sound entered Thumper's bones before it reached his ears.

Across the far wall, hundreds of screens displayed the forest. A rabbit clearing a field. Sparrows scattering from a branch. Perry the Possum speaking with Badger near a market stall. Images shifted, froze, and changed beneath rows of commands.

Thumper's mouth went dry.

"They can see everyone," Roost whispered.

"Not only see," said Wiseclaw. "They can interrupt, replace, and redirect."

On one screen, the Cult Leader stood before a bank of controls. His stern face appeared from several angles at once.

"Begin the second transmission," he ordered. "The forest must hear that the activists attacked first."

The Ex-Member gripped the railing. "That is the central command."

Slotholumule stepped beside them. His 4M FACE shirt was torn and gray with dust, but the painted letters remained visible.

"Then we have found what we came for," he said.

A warning tone rang through the cavern.

The white fire inside the Voice Engine flared.

Every screen turned toward the team.

The Cult Leader's image appeared on all of them. "You have entered the heart of Flat Earth HQ," he said. "Now the forest will watch you disappear."

Metal shutters began sliding over the exits.

Thumper looked at the towering machine, the sealed doors, and the cables carrying stolen voices beneath the earth. They had bypassed the crater's defenses, but the route had carried them straight into the trap.

He grabbed a dangling cable and yanked.

Sparks burst across the cavern. One bank of screens went dark.

The shutters stopped for half a second.

"Run!" Thumper shouted.

Slotholumule led the charge toward the central platform as alarms erupted and the Voice Engine began to wake. Behind them, the hidden tunnels sealed one by one, cutting off the path back to the surface.

CHAPTER 8

Rewrite History, Control Networks

“Run!” Thumper shouted.

Slotholumule led the charge toward the central platform as alarms erupted and the Voice Engine began to wake. Behind them, the hidden tunnels sealed one by one, cutting off the path back to the surface.

The floor shuddered beneath his claws. Blue light spilled from the machine’s rings, turning every face sharp and pale. Swiftwing shot overhead, beating through hot metal air, while Stoneback slammed his shell against a closing gate. The impact rang through the chamber.

“It won’t hold!” Stoneback called.

“Then find another way!” Slotholumule answered.

He hated the command as soon as it left him. They had crossed rivers, climbed a mountain pass under silver sheets of rain, and crawled through tunnels armed with cult darts. Now the base had swallowed them, and the Voice Engine was stirring around them like a waking beast.

A narrow service door snapped open beside the platform.

Wiseclaw seized Slotholumule’s sleeve. “There.”

They plunged through. Thumper followed with a squeak, and Swiftwing folded her wings just before the door slammed behind her. Stoneback squeezed through last, scraping the frame with his shell.

The corridor beyond was dark except for thin red strips along the floor. Warm air breathed from vents overhead. It smelled of oil, dust, and something bitter that clung to Slotholumule's tongue.

"Where are we going?" Thumper whispered.

"Somewhere we can hear them," Slotholumule said.

Wiseclaw's eyes narrowed. "Hear whom?"

Slotholumule pointed to the wall. A faint vibration traveled through the metal, carrying scraps of voices. The alarms had faded behind them, but the base was not quiet. Farther ahead, someone was speaking in a room sealed behind layers of steel.

Their goal had changed. Stopping the Voice Engine mattered, but they still did not know what the cult intended to broadcast. They needed the truth before they could protect the forest from it.

Swiftwing pressed one feather against the wall. "A meeting chamber. Three voices, perhaps four."

"Can we enter?" Stoneback asked.

"Not without announcing ourselves," Wiseclaw said.

Slotholumule studied the corridor. A glass panel sat above a maintenance hatch. Through it, cables twisted toward the hidden room. The panel was protected by a small brass lock stamped with the cult's white-circle symbol.

He reached for it.

Thumper caught his wrist. "That lock may scream."

"Then we make it whisper."

He drew a thin metal pick from the strap around his shirt. The painted words 4M FACE stretched across his chest, dulled by mud and tunnel dust. Fairness for all

creatures. The promise seemed almost too bright for a place built to bury the truth.

The pick clicked. A spark snapped against his claw.

Inside the wall, the voices sharpened.

" - the western relay is ready," said a smooth, impatient voice. "The forest settlements will receive the revised account before sunrise."

"Revised account?" Thumper mouthed.

Slotholumule raised one claw for silence.

A second voice answered. It was colder, heavier. The Cult Leader.

"Do not call it a revision, Perry. Call it the record."

Perry.

Slotholumule leaned closer to the panel. Through the glass, he saw a circular room lined with screens. Rivers of symbols crawled across them. Maps of the forest flickered beside images of crowded clearings, market paths, mountain trails, and distant settlements.

The Cult Leader stood at the center in his dark coat, hands clasped behind his back. Perry the Possum sat at a console, his paws moving over a bank of keys. Two cloaked figures stood near the far wall.

The sight of them made Slotholumule's stomach tighten. The Ex-Member had warned them that the cult's influence reached farther than the crater. This was not merely a hidden base. It was a factory for manufactured memory.

Perry tapped a key. One screen showed the overturned market cart from the forest clearing. The image shifted. The cracked wheel vanished, replaced by a clean cart and smiling merchants.

"By dawn," Perry said, "the public feed will show the activists attacking the market. Their arrival will be blamed for the shortages."

Thumper's ears flattened. "They're lying about the cart."

"They lied about our retreat," Swiftwing whispered. "They can make every eye see what they choose."

Stoneback's shell creaked as he tightened his stance. Slotholumule remembered the floodlights striking those old scratches white, while the Voice Engine had broadcast a false version of their flight. The lie had traveled faster than they could.

The Cult Leader turned toward a wall-sized map. Bright lines stretched from the crater across the forest and beyond it, connecting relay towers, signal nests, and distant cities.

"The world does not remember," he said. "It obeys the version repeated most often."

Perry's paws slowed. "And if anyone challenges it?"

"Flood the networks. Drown their testimony beneath our own. A thousand voices repeating the same history will make the truth sound like rebellion."

Slotholumule felt heat rise beneath his fur. He wanted to break the glass, cross the room, and force the Cult Leader to face every creature whose life he planned to erase. But the chamber held too many screens, too many cables, too many possible targets. One reckless strike could send the Engine's signal through every relay.

He needed proof. He needed the plan intact.

Wiseclaw pointed toward a small recording port beneath the panel. Slotholumule nodded. He eased a wire from his belt and pressed it into the port. The device gave a soft click.

Perry looked up.

Slotholumule froze.

"Did you hear that?" Perry asked.

The Cult Leader did not move. "The base is full of old machinery."

"No." Perry rose from his chair. "That was outside the chamber."

The cloaked figures turned toward the door.

"Keep recording," Slotholumule breathed.

Swiftwing's eyes flashed. "We should leave."

"Not yet."

Inside, Perry crossed to a smaller console. "The outer corridors are sealed. I can sweep the service passages."

A row of lights appeared on the wall map. One by one, they turned red.

The base had begun hunting them.

The Cult Leader's face hardened. "Activate the listening grid."

A low hum rolled through the corridor. Dust trembled from the ceiling. Slotholumule felt the vibration in his teeth.

"Now," he whispered.

He pulled the wire free, but the panel flashed white. A sharp tone pierced the corridor.

Perry pointed toward the wall. "There!"

The service door behind them burst open.

Black-feathered darts fired through the passage. Stoneback swung his shell into the first volley. Darts struck with hollow thuds, their white-circle markings gleaming

against the dark shell.

“Move!” Slotholumule shouted.

They raced deeper into the base. Red lights chased them along the floor. Swiftwing darted through a gap in the ceiling and cried out directions from above.

“Left! No - right! The left passage loops back!”

Thumper skidded around a corner. “They’re closing both!”

Slotholumule saw a control panel beside a heavy blast door. Symbols crawled across its surface, showing the base’s internal routes. He lunged toward it.

“If I open that door, we can reach the central platform,” he said.

Wiseclaw grabbed his shoulder. “Or release the guards.”

Behind them came the scrape of boots and the hiss of another dart launcher.

Slotholumule looked at the panel. The symbols blurred, but one line remained clear: GLOBAL RELAY ACCESS.

The cult’s network map was connected to the central platform. If he opened the door, they might reach the Voice Engine. If he failed, the entire team could be trapped between the guards and the sealed tunnels.

He drove his claw into the panel.

Sparks sprayed across his sleeve. The blast door groaned upward.

Cold air rushed through the opening, carrying the smell of ozone. Beyond lay a vast chamber filled with cables and rotating metal rings. At its center, the Voice Engine pulsed beneath a glass dome.

For one breath, Slotholumule saw the path ahead.

Then every screen in the room flickered.

The Cult Leader's face appeared above them.

"You came seeking the truth," he said. "How generous of you to bring it to us."

The blast door slammed down behind the team.

Metal shutters dropped over the exits. The red floor lights brightened until the chamber looked flooded with blood.

Thumper backed against Stoneback's shell. "We're locked in."

Slotholumule's recording wire was still clenched in his claw. The voices, the maps, the plan - they had proof, but no way to carry it out.

The Cult Leader's image smiled without warmth.

"By sunrise," he said, "the forest will remember you as enemies. By nightfall, it will remember that you never existed."

The Voice Engine surged to life.

Across the chamber, the rotating rings began to turn, and somewhere beyond the sealed doors, the cult's hunters started moving toward them.

CHAPTER 9

Cloak Ally from Inside

The rotating rings screamed awake, and Slotholumule saw his team reflected in their polished metal: five small figures trapped in a machine built to make lies sound official.

“Move!” he shouted.

The chamber doors slammed shut behind them. Red light spilled across the floor as the Voice Engine pushed out a deep, pulsing note. It vibrated through Slotholumule’s ribs and made the painted words on his shirt tremble against his fur: 4M FACE.

Fairness. A promise he had carried from the forest clearing to the crater’s edge. Now the promise felt heavier than his body.

Could he protect everyone without turning them into pieces on a board?

A burst of static cracked overhead. Then the Cult Leader’s voice rolled through the chamber.

“Seal every maintenance route. The intruders must not reach the surface.”

Thumper’s ears flattened. “That sounds personal.”

Wiseclaw swept one wing toward a narrow door beside the Voice Engine.

“Maintenance corridor. Before the locks cycle.”

Stoneback lowered his shell and charged. His shoulder struck the door with a boom, bending the metal inward. Swiftwing darted through the gap, feathers scraping the frame.

"Clear!" Swiftwing called.

Slotholumule grabbed the recorder strapped beneath his shirt. The tiny device held proof of the cult's plan to rewrite history and seize the forest's information networks. If they escaped, the evidence could reach every creature beyond the crater. If they were captured, the cult would erase it.

"Take the recorder," Slotholumule said.

Thumper stared at him. "You're carrying it."

"I'm the slowest target."

"That is not how targets work."

A second blast shook the chamber. Dust spilled from the ceiling. Beyond the sealed doors, boots struck metal stairs.

Slotholumule pushed through the broken doorway. "Go!"

They crowded into the maintenance corridor as the chamber lights snapped off behind them. The passage smelled of hot wires, oil, and damp stone. Pipes ran along the ceiling, rattling with every surge from the Voice Engine. Their claws and feet slapped against the grated floor.

The corridor split after a few body lengths. One branch sloped upward. The other vanished into darkness beneath a sign marked with the cult's white-circle symbol.

Wiseclaw leaned toward the sign. "The upward route leads to the relay rooms."

"Then we take it," Slotholumule said.

"No," said Stoneback. "The relay rooms will be guarded."

Thumper pointed down the dark branch. "And that one?"

"Cooling systems," Wiseclaw replied. "Dead end, according to the map."

A sharp click came from behind them.

Swiftwing looked back. "Hunters."

The broken door at the far end filled with moving silhouettes. A cult dart struck the pipe beside Slotholumule's head. Black feathers quivered. The white circle painted on the shaft seemed to stare at him.

"Up," Slotholumule said.

They ran.

The corridor narrowed until Stoneback had to turn sideways. Thumper slipped beneath a low pipe, then reached back to pull Wiseclaw through. Swiftwing flew ahead, but the ceiling was too low for a full wingbeat. He struck a hanging cable and spun into the wall.

"Swiftwing!" Slotholumule caught him before he fell through the railing.

"I'm fine," Swiftwing hissed, though one wing dragged.

The hunters were closer. Their voices bounced through the metal passage.

"Block the upper junction!"

"Search every door!"

Slotholumule's claws tightened around the recorder. He could hear the forest in his memory: the cracked market wheel, the overturned cart, creatures watching him decide whether peace meant staying quiet. He had promised fairness because silence had protected the wrong creatures for too long.

But leadership was not the same as throwing everyone into danger.

"Stop," he said.

Thumper nearly collided with him. "Now?"

"The relay room is a trap. We need the cooling system."

Wiseclaw's eyes narrowed. "The map says it ends."

"The map was missing sections," Slotholumule said. "The cult wanted us to believe the routes were simple."

Stoneback turned toward the dark branch. "You think there's another way."

"I think they built this place to hide things."

A dart hissed past and buried itself in the wall.

"Excellent theory," Thumper said. "Test it while moving."

Slotholumule led them into the darkness.

The temperature dropped at once. Cold air flowed over his face, carrying the mineral smell of underground water. Pipes thickened along the walls, each marked with faded arrows. The floor became slick. Somewhere below, machinery groaned like an animal trapped under stone.

Behind them, the hunters reached the junction.

"Down the cooling route!"

Slotholumule's stomach clenched. He had chosen this path, and now every friend followed him into it.

A steel gate dropped ahead.

Stoneback wedged his shell beneath it before it hit the floor. Metal shrieked against his back.

"Go!" Stoneback grunted.

Thumper squeezed under first. Wiseclaw followed, then Swiftwing. Slotholumule crawled after them, feeling the gate's heat against his shoulders.

Stoneback's legs shook.

Slotholumule reached back and pushed against the gate. "Hold on."

"I am holding on."

The hunters rounded the corner. Their lamps flashed across the corridor.

"Leave me," Stoneback said.

Slotholumule looked at the white circle on the nearest dart launcher. The cult always made sacrifice sound noble when it served their command. He would not let their logic enter his team.

"No."

He dug his claws into the gate's lower seam and pulled. Stoneback shoved upward with a roar. Together they lifted it just enough for the turtle to slide free. A dart struck Stoneback's shell and snapped.

They stumbled into a chamber crowded with cooling tanks. Frost coated the pipes. Blue fluid churned behind thick glass, casting the room in an icy glow.

At the center stood a control panel with no markings except a single handprint.

Wiseclaw examined it. "The cooling system is not a dead end. It feeds the central command."

"Can it open a route out?" Slotholumule asked.

"Perhaps. But activating it may shut down the Voice Engine."

Thumper's face brightened. "That sounds useful."

"It may also flood this corridor with steam," Wiseclaw said.

The gate behind them rattled. The hunters were forcing it open.

Slotholumule stared at the handprint. If he pressed it, the machine might give them an escape. It might also burn his friends alive. If he did nothing, the hunters would take the recorder and drag them back to the chamber.

His fear had a simple voice.

Do not choose for them.

He placed his palm against the panel.

Nothing happened.

Then a figure dropped from a pipe above.

A dark cloak swept across the blue light. The stranger landed between Slotholumule and the control panel, holding a short metal blade. A white circle had been cut from the cloak's shoulder, leaving a ragged hole.

Thumper raised a fist. Stoneback lowered his head.

"Back away," Swiftwing warned.

The stranger lifted both hands. "If I meant to hurt you, the hunters would already be inside."

The gate groaned again.

Slotholumule kept his palm on the panel. "Who are you?"

The figure's hood turned toward the recorder beneath his shirt.

"You stole proof from the history chamber," they said. "Then the Cult Leader ordered Perry the Possum to erase the original files."

Slotholumule's breath caught. "You were there."

"I helped build the erasure system."

Silence pressed between the tanks.

Thumper's voice hardened. "You're one of them."

"I was."

"Cultists don't become allies because they change cloaks."

The stranger lowered the blade. "No. They become allies when they return to the place where they helped cause harm and open the doors they once locked."

The gate burst upward. Three hunters surged through.

The cloaked figure spun and struck the nearest lamp. Darkness swallowed the chamber. A flash of blue fluid lit the room as the stranger kicked a loose pipe into the hunters' legs. Metal clanged. Someone shouted.

"Press the panel!" the stranger cried.

Slotholumule pressed harder.

The handprint flared red.

Steam exploded from the walls.

Stoneback pulled Thumper behind a tank. Swiftwing beat his good wing once and dragged Wiseclaw toward a ladder. Slotholumule felt heat bite through his fur as the chamber filled with white vapor.

The stranger seized his wrist. "Not that way. The ladder leads to the broadcast vents."

"Where do we go?"

"Follow me."

They plunged through a narrow opening behind the largest cooling tank. The stranger had hidden a release lever under a crust of frost. With a twist, they opened a passage barely wide enough for Slotholumule.

The hunters fired blindly into the steam. Darts struck glass. One tank cracked.

"Keep moving!" Wiseclaw shouted.

They crawled through a tunnel lined with old cables. The stranger came last, sealing the opening behind them. A muffled boom rolled through the passage.

"What did you do?" Slotholumule asked.

"Broke the pressure lock."

"Will that stop the Voice Engine?"

"For a few minutes."

The stranger pulled back the hood. Their face was marked by a thin scar from brow to jaw, and their eyes held the exhausted watchfulness of someone who had spent too long expecting punishment.

"My name does not matter," they said.

"Then we'll call you Ex-Member," Thumper said. "It's accurate."

The Ex-Member glanced at him. "Fair enough."

Slotholumule studied the scar, then the torn white circle. "You know the base."

"I know the command routes, the false doors, the patrol signals, and the emergency controls. I know where the Cult Leader keeps the global communications device."

Stoneback's expression tightened. "The device that alters every broadcast?"

"The Voice Engine is only the amplifier. The device beneath central command chooses what the forest hears. Destroying the amplifier will not end the control."

Slotholumule felt the recorder press against his chest. Proof could expose the cult, but only if the forest still had a way to hear it.

"Can you get us there?" he asked.

The Ex-Member nodded. "I can get you close."

"Close is not enough."

"It will have to be. The Cult Leader has begun moving the device."

A tremor passed through the tunnel. Dust sifted from the ceiling. Far behind them, metal doors slammed in sequence.

Wiseclaw looked toward the sound. "The pressure lock is failing."

"The hunters will seal this route," Ex-Member said. "We have minutes."

Thumper pointed at Slotholumule. "Tell me we have a plan."

Slotholumule wanted to say yes. He wanted to sound as certain as he had in the forest clearing, when creatures needed a promise more than they needed to see his fear.

Instead, he looked at his team.

Stoneback's shell was scratched and pierced. Swiftwing's wing trembled. Wiseclaw's feathers were damp with steam. Thumper's ears were pinned flat, but he had not stepped away.

"We reach central command," Slotholumule said. "We protect the recorder. We expose the truth before they can broadcast another lie."

The Ex-Member shook their head. "There is one more condition."

“What?”

“To reach the command room, someone must trigger the inner gate from inside the security grid. Once it closes, that someone cannot come back out.”

The tunnel seemed to shrink around them.

Thumper’s eyes flashed. “You knew that before you brought us here.”

“I knew it before I chose to help.”

Slotholumule felt the old fear return, sharper now. He had asked for an ally and found someone already preparing to pay the price.

He stepped closer. “No one gets left behind.”

The Ex-Member met his gaze. “Then find another way quickly.”

Another tremor shook the cables overhead. From the darkness behind them came the hiss of opening locks.

The Ex-Member turned and pointed toward a ladder rising through the rock.

“Move,” they said. “The Cult Leader is carrying the device to the upper command room, and every second we spend arguing belongs to him.”

Slotholumule climbed first, the recorder tight against his chest. Behind him, his team followed into the cold machinery shaft.

For the first time since the hunters had begun moving, the way forward was no longer a guess.

It was a path drawn by someone who knew every secret door.

And somewhere above, the Voice Engine began to broadcast again.



Central Command Infiltration Plan

The broadcast trembled through the junction hall, turning every iron beam into a humming throat.

Swiftwing clung to a rusted cable above the floor and watched the path ahead flicker beneath strips of blue light. The ex-member stood below, cloak dripping from the tunnel's damp air, one gloved hand pressed against the stone wall. Behind them, the sealed passage gave a final metallic groan.

"There," Ex-Member whispered. "The central command route begins beyond that gate."

Swiftwing's feathers prickled. The Voice Engine's latest lie rolled through the walls in a calm, polished voice.

"Unauthorized intruders have abandoned the facility. The forest remains safe under Flat Earth HQ protection."

Stoneback scraped one heavy foot against the floor. "It knows we're here."

"It knows someone is here," Wiseclaw said. The old fox crouched beside a row of brass plates set into the stone. "That is not the same thing."

Slotholumule moved beside him, his 4M FACE shirt darkened by sweat and tunnel mist. "We have the recording of the Cult Leader and Perry. We need the source device itself. If we reach central command, we can expose the Voice Engine before it rewrites every message sent through the forest."

Swiftwing dropped lightly to the floor. "Then we need to know which door gets us there."

Ex-Member turned toward the junction. Five tunnels opened from the hall, each marked by a different symbol: a black feather, a white circle, a broken wheel, a closed eye, and a line pointing downward. Thin wires crossed the ceiling like spider silk. Somewhere behind the walls, gears clicked in patient rhythm.

"The cult changes the route when an alarm begins," Ex-Member said. "The signs are not directions. They are questions."

Thumper's ears lifted. "Questions?"

"Which passage do you trust? Which symbol do you fear? Which sound do you follow?" Ex-Member's voice tightened. "They want intruders to choose quickly."

Swiftwing studied the hall. The black-feather symbol matched the darts that had nearly pierced Thumper in the trap passage. The broken wheel recalled the neglected cart that had first drawn Slotholumule into the fight. The closed eye seemed harmless, but a faint warmth breathed from the stones around it.

"What happens if we choose wrong?" Swiftwing asked.

Ex-Member looked at the ceiling. "The hall seals. Then the Voice Engine records our voices and uses them to identify everyone who helped us."

A low hiss slid through the junction. One of the blue lights blinked red.

Slotholumule's gaze settled on Swiftwing. "Can you scout the upper vents?"

Swiftwing felt the weight of every face turn toward her. "I can."

"Find the command route. No heroics."

She gave him a sharp look. "You say that as if heroics are the only thing I'm good at."

"Fast eyes," Slotholumule replied. "Fast wings. That is what we need."

The compliment landed harder than a command. Swiftwing spread her wings and sprang toward the cable. Cold air rushed beneath her as she climbed into the narrow vent above the junction. The metal scraped her talons, and the smell of oil grew stronger.

Below, the others faded into silhouettes.

"Three breaths," Wiseclaw called softly. "Then report."

Swiftwing crawled through the vent until it divided. To the left came a steady pulse, like a giant heart. To the right came voices.

She edged toward the voices and peered through a grille.

Two cult guards stood in a chamber lined with listening horns. A thin sheet of paper glowed on a table between them. Words appeared across its surface, then vanished.

"Central command is shifting," one guard said. "The Leader wants the north relay sealed."

"The intruders are still trapped in the junction."

Swiftwing pulled back before the guards could glance upward. North relay. The hall's symbols had no north marker. She scanned the vent floor and found a narrow groove cut into the metal. It angled toward the closed-eye symbol.

She tapped the groove twice against the grille, then flew back.

"The closed eye," she whispered when she landed. "The route bends north. Guards are sealing the north relay."

Ex-Member's head snapped toward the symbol. "No. That passage leads to the archives."

"Then the guards are lying," Thumper said.

"Or the Voice Engine is feeding them false orders," Wiseclaw murmured.

A burst of static cracked through the hall. Every symbol lit at once.

Swiftwing flinched as a voice emerged from the stone.

"State your allegiance."

Thumper bared his teeth. "I'm allergic to questions."

The voice repeated itself, louder. "State your allegiance."

Slotholumule stepped forward. "We stand with the forest."

The brass plates flashed. A sharp tone rang out, and the broken-wheel symbol went dark.

Ex-Member grabbed Slotholumule's arm. "It is measuring your words."

"Then let it measure," Slotholumule said. "We are not hiding what we came to do."

The hall shuddered. A seam opened beneath the black-feather symbol, revealing a stairwell descending into darkness.

Stoneback blocked it with his shell. "That opened too easily."

Swiftwing looked at the stairwell. "The engine expects us to take the obvious route."

"Which means the closed eye?" Thumper asked.

"Maybe," said Wiseclaw. "The question is not which door is safe. It is which door the cult believes we will avoid."

Ex-Member knelt beside the closed-eye plate. Their gloved fingers traced its rim. "The archives are protected by memory locks. I was never allowed inside."

"Can you open it?" Swiftwing asked.

"No."

The answer came too quickly. Swiftwing noticed the way Ex-Member's hand remained pressed to the plate.

"You know something."

Ex-Member withdrew their hand. "I know the cost of entering."

"Then tell us."

For a moment, only the humming walls answered. The ex-member's hood hid their face, but their shoulders bowed beneath the silence.

"The archive route passes the command pathway," they said at last. "It also passes the identity chamber. Anyone crossing it is marked by the Engine. Once marked, every broadcast tower in the forest can recognize their voice."

Stoneback's claws tightened against the floor. "So the safest route is the one that makes us easiest to hunt."

"Not safest," Slotholumule said. "Necessary."

Swiftwing looked at him. "If the device is destroyed, the broadcasts stop. But if we are marked first, the cult can twist our voices before we reach the surface."

"We have the recording," Wiseclaw said. "Proof of what they intend."

"Proof can be buried," Slotholumule answered. "The device cannot argue once it is broken."

The red light above them began to pulse faster.

From the black-feather stairwell came the scrape of boots.

Ex-Member rose. "They have found the junction."

Slotholumule turned to the closed-eye symbol. "Open it."

"I said I cannot."

"Then show us what you were taught."

The ex-member stared at him. Swiftwing saw fear move through the narrow gap beneath the hood.

"Cult members placed a hand over the eye," Ex-Member said. "They spoke the first version of the forest's history."

"And what did you speak?" Swiftwing asked.

The ex-member's voice dropped. "The version they wanted."

Boots struck the stairs. A metal latch slammed somewhere behind them.

Swiftwing darted to the plate and pressed her wing against it. "Then speak the truth now."

Ex-Member's gloved hand covered hers. The plate was cold enough to numb her feathers.

"I helped them erase names," they said. "I helped them turn peaceful protests into crimes. I helped them make the forest believe that silence was safety."

Slotholumule's expression softened, but his voice remained firm. "And now?"

"Now I want the names returned."

Ex-Member placed both hands over the closed eye.

"Every creature deserves to be heard," they said. "No leader owns the truth. No machine can make injustice fair."

The symbol flickered.

The boots reached the junction entrance.

"Again!" Wiseclaw barked.

Ex-Member pressed harder. "The forest remembers."

The closed eye split open with a flash of white light. A narrow doorway appeared, revealing a passage filled with pale dust and hanging wires.

"Move!" Slotholumule shouted.

Thumper bounded through first. Stoneback followed, scraping the doorframe. Wiseclaw vanished beneath the wires, and Slotholumule caught Ex-Member by the sleeve as guards burst from the black-feather stairwell.

A dart struck the stone where Slotholumule's head had been.

Swiftwing shot into the passage and wheeled back. "The wires are live!"

"I see them," Thumper called.

"No, you don't." She pointed to a nearly invisible strand crossing the floor. "That one is under tension."

Stoneback froze with one foot raised.

Behind them, the guards poured into the junction. Their masks reflected the blue lights, giving them blank, shining faces.

"Central command is ahead," Ex-Member said. "The identity chamber lies beyond the next turn."

"How far?" Slotholumule asked.

"Close enough to hear the Engine."

A deep vibration rolled through the passage. The walls trembled. Somewhere ahead, a bell began to toll.

Swiftwing flew upward and found a cluster of vents above the wires. "There's a gap on the left. One at a time."

Thumper crouched and slid beneath the first strand. Stoneback moved next, slow as shifting rock. Wiseclaw held the hanging wires aside while Slotholumule guided Ex-Member through.

The guards reached the doorway.

A dart snapped past Swiftwing's wing and struck the wall. Black feathers quivered around the white circle.

She dove, seized a loose cable in her beak, and yanked.

Sparks burst across the passage. The guards stumbled as the doorway slammed halfway shut.

"Swiftwing!" Slotholumule shouted.

"I'm coming!"

She darted through the narrowing gap. Stoneback shoved the door with his shell until it sealed behind them. The guards' pounding became a muffled thunder.

For three breaths, nobody moved.

Then the bell stopped.

A strip of red light ignited along the floor.

Ex-Member went still. "That is the identity chamber."

The passage ahead divided again. One branch climbed toward a door marked with the cult's white circle. The other descended toward a distant mechanical roar.

"The command pathway is below," Ex-Member said. "But the alarm has started. The Engine will lock every relay once it confirms our voices."

Slotholumule looked at the descending route. "How do we get past the chamber?"

Ex-Member pointed to a narrow ledge along the wall. "We cross without touching the red line. If anyone steps into it, the chamber records the signal."

Swiftwing rose to scout, but a fresh tone pierced the passage. The red line surged brighter, and the walls began sliding inward.

"There's no time," Wiseclaw said.

Slotholumule's eyes met Swiftwing's. "Can you reach the far switch?"

She glanced at the narrowing ledge. "Yes."

"Then go."

Swiftwing launched. Heat brushed her underside as the red line flared below. She flew between the closing walls, past hanging wires and spinning metal teeth. At the far end, a switch waited behind a grille.

She struck it with both feet.

The grille snapped shut around her talons.

Below, Slotholumule shouted her name. The alarm bell began again, faster now, each note punching through the metal.

Swiftwing twisted, pulled, and felt one talon tear free. Pain flashed through her wing. She kicked the switch a second time.

The wall halted.

The command pathway opened below them, a black corridor descending toward the roar of the Voice Engine.

They had found the route.

But the alarm had found them too.

Ex-Member stepped into the corridor first. "Once we enter, there is no quiet way back."

Slotholumule followed, his claws closing around the recorded proof. "Then we make enough noise for the whole forest to hear."

Swiftwing tucked her injured talon against her feathers and flew after them. Behind her, the identity chamber began to speak in her own voice.

"Unauthorized intruders detected."

Ahead, central command thundered awake.

Disabling Traps Without Losing Time

“Unauthorized intruders detected.”

The warning struck the corridor in three directions at once. Stoneback felt it vibrate through his shell before the red lamps began flashing. Dust sifted from the ceiling. Ahead, iron plates snapped open, revealing rows of black-feathered darts.

“Down!” Stoneback shouted.

He dropped hard, scraping one knee against the stone. Swiftwing folded her wings and slid beneath him. Thumper flattened against the wall, while Wiseclaw seized Slotholumule by the shirt and pulled him behind a jutting support.

The first volley cracked through the passage. Darts punched into the opposite wall, their white-circle markings bright beneath the alarm lights. One struck Stoneback’s shell and skittered away with a sharp metallic chirp.

“Everyone breathing?” Slotholumule asked.

“Breathing,” Thumper whispered. “Not enjoying it.”

Stoneback raised his head. At the far end, a bronze door pulsed with lines of blue light. Beyond it lay the control center - and the device that could twist every message carried through the forest. Their proof was hidden in Wiseclaw’s recording crystal, but proof meant little if the cult reached the broadcast controls first.

“We need that door,” Stoneback said. “Before the hunters reach this corridor.”

A low clank answered him from behind.

Stoneback turned. Panels were sliding shut along the passage they had entered. The alarm had not merely awakened the traps. It had divided the tunnels, sealing them inside a narrowing throat of stone.

Ex-Member pressed a gloved hand to the wall, listening. "Patrols are moving from the junction. Three squads. Maybe four."

"How long?" Swiftwing asked.

"Less than a minute."

Stoneback studied the dart ports. The mechanism worked in cycles. A thin copper rod ran beneath the floor, trembling each time the warning bell sounded. Beside it, a narrow maintenance grate had been left loose.

"Wiseclaw," he said, "can you reach the control wire?"

The turtle's eyes followed his gaze. "If the next volley doesn't turn me into a pincushion."

"Then we make the next volley miss."

Stoneback shifted his weight and placed his shell against the wall. The old scratches across it caught the red light, reminders of every road that had demanded more than he could give. Slotholumule moved beside him.

"No," Slotholumule said. "We do it together."

Stoneback almost laughed. "You're a sloth. The dart ports don't care about fairness."

"They care about pressure," Wiseclaw said. "And you're the only one built like a shield."

Another clank rolled through the corridor. The copper rod shuddered.

Stoneback leaned forward. "When I move, Wiseclaw goes for the grate. Swiftwing, watch the ceiling. Thumper, find the release for those panels. Slotholumule, stay with

Ex-Member and get us to the door.”

“And you?” Slotholumule asked.

“I’ll give the traps something large to worry about.”

The alarm shrieked.

Stoneback lunged.

Darts burst from the walls. They struck his shell in a storm of clicks, some glancing away, others lodging in the thick outer plates. Pain flashed across his back, hot and sudden. He kept moving, dragging his shell along the corridor so the darts aimed at him instead of the others.

Wiseclaw slid low across the floor. His claws hooked the grate and tore it free. A nest of wires glimmered beneath.

“Blue wire?” Wiseclaw called.

“Red,” Ex-Member answered. “Blue feeds the ports.”

Wiseclaw’s claw hovered. “There are three reds.”

“The middle one.”

The turtle cut it.

Every dart port slammed shut.

For one breath, the corridor went quiet except for Stoneback’s rough breathing. Then a bell began ringing somewhere beyond the bronze door.

“Not quiet enough,” Swiftwing said.

Above them, a panel opened. A glass lens rotated toward the team.

“Identity scan,” Ex-Member warned.

Stoneback saw the lens brighten. If it completed its sweep, the cult would have their faces, their voices, their exact location. He reached for the nearest hanging cable and yanked.

The lens swung sideways. Its beam struck the wall, carving a white line through the dust.

"Move!" Stoneback barked.

They raced - or stumbled, in Slotholumule's case - toward the bronze door. Thumper reached the wall panel first and slammed both paws against it. The door remained shut.

"Locked!"

Ex-Member pulled a narrow strip of metal from beneath the cloak. "It recognizes authorized voices."

A boot struck the sealed panels behind them.

"Then use one," Stoneback said.

Ex-Member froze. "My voice is flagged."

The boot struck again. A seam appeared in the rear doors.

Slotholumule stepped closer. "You know their words."

"I know what they made me say."

"Then say something they cannot twist."

Ex-Member looked at the recording crystal in Wiseclaw's grip. Their shoulders tightened beneath the cloak.

"The cult's oath," they whispered. "It opens command doors."

Stoneback heard the shame beneath the words. He also heard the hunters forcing their way through.

“Say it,” he said. “This time, we decide what it means.”

Ex-Member faced the panel. Their voice trembled once, then steadied.

“Truth belongs to every creature.”

The blue lines on the door flickered.

Behind them, metal screamed. A gloved hand pushed through the widening gap.

Ex-Member continued. “No leader owns the past. No machine owns the voice of the forest.”

The panel flashed green.

The bronze door opened just wide enough for Thumper. He squeezed through and pulled the release from the other side. The gap widened. Swiftwing shot in first, followed by Wiseclaw and Slotholumule.

Stoneback turned back.

Ex-Member was still outside.

“Come on!” Slotholumule called.

A hunter’s arm thrust through the broken seal, reaching for Ex-Member’s cloak. Ex-Member twisted away, but the fabric caught. Stoneback drove his shoulder into the door. The hunter grunted. The cloak tore free, leaving Ex-Member stumbling into the chamber.

The door slammed shut.

For several seconds, nobody moved. The chamber beyond was colder than the corridor, its walls lined with thick glass tubes. Inside them, pale signals raced like

captive lightning. Each pulse carried fragments of voices: market announcements, forest warnings, old speeches, altered memories.

Stoneback felt the darts buried in his shell shift as he breathed.

Thumper stared at him. "You're hit."

"Shell's hit."

"That is not the same as fine."

"No," Stoneback admitted. "It isn't."

Slotholumule placed a careful hand against one of the embedded darts. "Can you keep moving?"

Stoneback looked past him.

At the far side of the chamber, a narrow corridor descended toward a pair of black doors. Above them, a painted symbol showed a globe split by a straight line. Beneath it, a single word glowed in white:

CONTROL.

The device was close. Stoneback could feel its vibration through the floor, a deep mechanical throb that matched the alarm.

"Yes," he said. "I can keep moving."

A speaker crackled overhead.

"Stoneback," said the Cult Leader. "You have always mistaken endurance for strength."

The team stiffened.

The stern human's voice filled the chamber, smooth and certain. "Your friends will tire. Your evidence will be dismissed. But the Voice Engine will continue. By dawn, every

creature in the forest will remember the history we give them.”

Slotholumule looked up. “They will remember what happened here.”

A harsh laugh answered him. “Only if they hear you.”

The glass tubes brightened. Voices poured through the chamber, overlapping until Stoneback heard his own name spoken in accusation, then in mockery, then as if he had never existed.

Wiseclaw gripped the recording crystal. “He’s using the relay chamber to drown the signal.”

“Can we shut it down?” Swiftwing asked.

“Not from here.”

“Then the control center,” Slotholumule said.

The black doors at the end of the passage opened.

Not all the way. Just enough to reveal a corridor beyond, lined with rotating mirrors. At its center, a thin green beam stretched from floor to ceiling.

Ex-Member went still. “That beam marks the final security grid.”

Stoneback watched the mirrors turn. Each reflected a different angle of the team, multiplying them into a crowd of intruders.

“Can it be crossed?” he asked.

“Yes,” Ex-Member said. “But the grid counts movement. Every interruption triggers the patrol signal.”

Behind the bronze door, the hunters began pounding again.

Stoneback looked at the darts lodged in his shell, then at Slotholumule's shirt. The painted words 4M FACE were dusty but visible: fairness for every creature.

"We've already triggered the signal," Stoneback said. "Now we stop letting it choose our pace."

He stepped into the mirror corridor.

The green beam touched his shell. A pulse raced along the floor.

Stoneback froze.

The mirrors shifted, searching for motion. In one reflection, he saw the hunters breach the chamber behind them. In another, he saw Slotholumule reaching for him. In a third, the black control doors stood open, revealing a vast room crowded with rings of machinery.

Stoneback lifted one foot and placed it down between two strips of light.

The beam followed.

"Left," Wiseclaw whispered. "Two inches."

Stoneback moved left.

A mirror clicked. The beam split.

Swiftwing darted through the opening before it closed. Thumper followed, holding his breath. Slotholumule came last, slow and deliberate, while Ex-Member watched the reflections.

"Stop," Ex-Member said.

Slotholumule halted with one paw raised.

A thin red line appeared across the floor before him.

"Step back," Stoneback said.

"I can't. The beam is behind me."

The hunters burst into the relay chamber. Their boots struck the glass floor. A voice shouted for the alarm to be raised.

Stoneback saw the mirrors tilt toward Slotholumule. The grid had found its target.

He drove his shell into the nearest mirror.

Glass exploded across the corridor. The green beam snapped sideways, striking the ceiling. Every alarm in the relay chamber erupted at once.

Stoneback staggered, shards biting into his foreleg. Swiftwing seized Slotholumule and pulled him through the gap.

"Stoneback!"

"Go!"

The black doors began closing.

Ex-Member reached for Stoneback's arm. Together they pushed through as the doors crashed down behind them. On the other side, the alarms became muffled, but not silent. Red light pulsed along the new corridor, racing toward the control center.

They had crossed the grid.

They had also announced exactly where they were.

At the corridor's end, a round window revealed the final room. Massive rings turned around a central column of white fire. Cables spread from it like roots, disappearing into the rock and beyond, toward the forest's communication towers.

The global communications device was no longer a distant threat. It was just beyond the next door.

Then the speaker above them clicked on again.

“Open the corridor,” ordered the Cult Leader.

Locks began releasing one by one.

Ex-Member looked at the control room, then back at the sealed passage behind them.

“We have seconds.”

Stoneback pressed his injured foreleg against his shell and tasted blood where he had bitten his tongue. The team gathered close. Slotholumule’s eyes stayed fixed on the white fire.

“Then we use every one,” Stoneback said.

The final lock released.

Beyond the door, the Voice Engine’s rings accelerated, and the control center filled with the sound of history being rewritten.

CHAPTER 12

The Global Communications Device

The final lock released with a shriek, and Slotholumule lunged through before the door could slam shut again.

A ring of polished metal swept past his face. Heat rolled from the machine in waves, carrying the sharp smell of burnt copper. He dropped beneath it, claws scraping the black floor, while Swiftwing flashed overhead and Stoneback shoved Thumper clear of a shower of sparks.

“Stay together!” Slotholumule called.

His voice came back from every wall, twisted into a dozen false echoes.

The control center opened around them like the inside of a buried storm. Towers of glass and brass rose from the floor. Cables crawled across the ceiling. At the chamber’s heart, five enormous rings revolved around a dark console, each one carved with maps, arrows, and the white-circle mark of Flat Earth HQ.

Beyond the console stood the Cult Leader.

He rested one hand on a lever and watched them with the same stern calm he had worn at the crater’s edge. Perry the Possum stood beside him, pale and trembling, both paws hovering over a bank of glowing keys.

“You arrived just in time,” the Cult Leader said. “The forest is listening.”

Slotholumule felt the old dart wound pull beneath his shirt. The painted words on his chest - 4M FACE - were damp with sweat, but the promise they carried steadied him.

"Then let it listen to the truth," he said. "Step away from that console."

A low tone rolled through the chamber. The rings slowed.

Wiseclaw lifted the recording crystal. Its blue light flickered against his feathers. "We have your plans recorded. The forest will hear what you intended."

Perry's eyes darted toward the crystal. "He knows. He knows everything."

"Perry," the Cult Leader snapped.

The possum flinched.

Slotholumule took one careful step forward. He wanted the console stopped, not merely damaged. If the Voice Engine completed its cycle, every message moving through the forest's communication lines could be altered before it reached its destination. Warnings could become invitations. Witnesses could be made to sound like liars. A plea for help could vanish beneath a false report.

"Tell us what this machine is doing," Slotholumule said.

The Cult Leader smiled without warmth. "You still think this is a broadcast tower."

The rings began turning again.

Swiftwing swooped toward the nearest control bank, but a wall of blue light snapped into place. He veered hard, feathers singed by the barrier.

"Not that way!" Wiseclaw shouted. "The field is tied to the outer ring."

Thumper bounded toward another panel. A metal arm sprang from the floor and struck the stone beside his foot. He twisted away, ears flattened.

Stoneback planted himself between Thumper and the machine. Another arm hammered his shell with a sound like a bell. He grunted, but held his ground.

"Find the shutoff!" Slotholumule cried.

"I'm looking!" Wiseclaw answered.

The chamber filled with voices. Some were real, some recorded, some manufactured by the Engine. Slotholumule heard a badger calling for aid, then heard his own voice ordering the forest creatures to abandon their homes. He heard Swiftwing confessing to a crime he had never committed. He heard Stoneback begging the cult for mercy.

The lies struck harder because they wore familiar voices.

The Cult Leader pulled the lever halfway down.

A red line appeared across the console. Symbols raced along it, too fast for Slotholumule to read.

"What did you activate?" he demanded.

"Not a local transmission," said the Cult Leader. "A global one."

The word seemed to widen the chamber.

Wiseclaw's recording crystal flashed. "Global communications alteration," he whispered. "He's routing the Engine through every relay."

"Can you stop it?" Slotholumule asked.

"Not from here. The controls are locked behind a command phrase."

"Then we find the phrase."

The team scattered across the chamber. Slotholumule moved along the console's edge, searching for anything the Cult Leader might have hidden. The metal was warm beneath his claws. Every panel displayed a different fragment: river routes, market signals, emergency channels, old news records. Some showed the forest as it was. Others showed disasters that had never happened.

At the far side, Ex-Member emerged from a narrow service passage. Their cloak was torn where the bronze door had caught it, and one shoulder dragged low.

"The command phrase isn't written," Ex-Member said. "It's spoken."

The Cult Leader turned sharply. "You."

"I know what you built."

"You know what you abandoned."

Ex-Member stepped closer, keeping their eyes on the console. "The phrase changes with each cycle. But the machine recognizes the voice that installed it."

Slotholumule looked from Ex-Member to the Cult Leader. "Then make him speak."

The Cult Leader's hand moved toward a black switch.

Slotholumule sprang.

He crossed the space in three slow, powerful bounds, but a pulse burst from the console and knocked him sideways. He struck the floor, tasting iron. The Cult Leader seized the moment and swung the lever down.

The rings screamed.

Across the chamber, every screen went white. Then a single number appeared.

TEN.

"Countdown!" Wiseclaw shouted.

"Nine," said the machine.

Thumper slammed both feet into the base of a relay tower. The tower rocked but did not fall. Swiftwing darted through the air, pecking at a cable junction, while Stoneback wedged his shell against a closing gate.

"Eight."

Slotholumule rose. The Cult Leader stood between him and the console, one hand gripping the lever, the other holding a small metal key.

"Give me that key," Slotholumule said.

"Seven."

"You can still stop this."

"No," said the Cult Leader. "I can only decide who controls the story afterward."

"Six."

Slotholumule charged. The Cult Leader met him with a shock baton. Blue fire crawled across Slotholumule's arms. His muscles locked, and he fell to one knee.

The Cult Leader leaned close. "Peace is useful when frightened creatures mistake silence for fairness."

Slotholumule forced his claws against the floor. "Fairness doesn't need silence."

He twisted, dragging the baton down with him. The Cult Leader stumbled. Slotholumule struck the man's wrist, and the metal key flew beneath the console.

"Five."

Perry dropped beside it.

"Perry!" the Cult Leader shouted.

The possum reached into the darkness. His paw closed around the key, but instead of handing it back, he held it against his chest.

The Cult Leader's face hardened. "You helped build this."

"I helped make voices obey," Perry said. His voice shook, but it carried. "I didn't know you meant to erase everyone else."

"Four."

Wiseclaw pointed toward a narrow slot beneath the console. "The key goes there!"

Perry tossed it. Slotholumule caught it against his palm.

He ran.

A blast struck the floor behind him. Stoneback had been forced back from the gate, and one of the machine arms swung toward Thumper. Swiftwing dived, knocking Thumper aside, but the arm clipped his wing. He crashed against a pillar.

"Three."

Slotholumule reached the slot. The key slid in, but the lock rejected it with a harsh click.

"Wrong side!" Ex-Member yelled. "Turn it twice!"

He turned it.

The console opened like a metal jaw. Inside, hundreds of thin wires pulsed with colored light. At the center sat a small glass sphere, bright as a captured sunrise.

"Two."

The Cult Leader seized Slotholumule from behind. The baton pressed against his throat.

"Remove the key," the man hissed.

Slotholumule stared into the glass sphere. Within it, tiny lights moved along invisible paths, racing outward toward the forest, the mountains, the rivers, and places far beyond them.

He could not reach the wires without being shocked. He could not fight the Cult Leader without losing the last seconds. Around him, his friends struggled against the

machine's defenses.

Then Ex-Member stepped onto the central platform.

"One."

The rings stopped.

For a breath, the chamber went silent.

Ex-Member tore open their cloak and revealed a band of metal wrapped around their chest. Symbols glowed across it - the same symbols that covered the console.

The Cult Leader released Slotholumule and stared. "No."

Ex-Member pressed both hands to the central ring.

The machine recognized them.

Every panel turned toward the platform. The glass sphere flared, and a violent current surged through Ex-Member's body. Their knees buckled, but they held on.

"Now!" Ex-Member cried.

Slotholumule drove his shoulder into the Cult Leader. The man slammed against the console. Slotholumule seized the key, turned it once more, and reached into the open housing.

The glass sphere burned his claws.

"Break the relay!" Wiseclaw shouted.

Slotholumule closed his eyes and pulled.

The sphere tore free.

Light exploded across the chamber. The rings spun backward, shrieking as every false voice collapsed into one deafening burst. Swiftwing covered his injured wing.

Stoneback lowered his head. Thumper curled beside him.

Ex-Member cried out.

Slotholumule looked back. The metal band had fused to the central ring, and the machine was drawing power through them to keep itself alive.

“Let go!” he shouted.

“I can’t.”

The Cult Leader staggered upright. “You’ll destroy the whole network!”

“That is the point!” Ex-Member said.

Slotholumule gripped the glass sphere with both claws. It pulsed against his palms, filled with stolen messages and trapped voices.

The device had not stopped.

It had only changed its target.

The rings began accelerating again, and a new countdown appeared across every screen.

TEN.

Ex-Member looked at Slotholumule through the storm of white light.

“Destroy the sphere,” they said. “Before it reaches the world.”

Slotholumule raised the glowing core above his head as the Cult Leader lunged toward him.

Behind them, the first relay tower ignited.



The Ex-Member's Truth Sacrifice

“Drop it, Slotholumule!” the Cult Leader roared. “That core belongs to the Voice Engine!”

Thumper sprang across the console platform as the first relay tower flared beyond the chamber walls. Blue-white light poured through the glass panels, turning every metal ring into a spinning blade of sun. Slotholumule stood at the center, the glowing core clutched above his head, while the Cult Leader lunged through the sparks.

Thumper struck the leader's legs with both hind feet. The human stumbled, but his hand caught the edge of the console. A shock snapped through the platform. Thumper's fur prickled, and the bitter smell of burned metal filled his nose.

“Slotholumule, now!” he shouted.

The sloth twisted toward the central housing. “Wiseclaw, find the release!”

“It has no release!” Wiseclaw called from the lower rail. “The core is locked into the broadcast cycle!”

A deep note rolled through the chamber. It vibrated in Thumper's ribs and made his teeth ache. Above them, the Voice Engine's rings accelerated, flinging bands of light across the ceiling. Voices spilled from hidden speakers - forest announcements, market bells, pleas for help - each one bending into the Cult Leader's stern command.

“Flat Earth HQ speaks for every creature,” the broadcast declared. “Doubt is disorder. Obedience is peace.”

Thumper's ears flattened. He had heard those words in the forest before, twisted and polished until fear sounded like law. He looked at Slotholumule's shirt, the painted 4M FACE slogan bright beneath the machine's glare.

"Don't let it speak for us!" Thumper cried.

The Ex-Member moved before anyone else could answer. The cloaked ally slammed both hands onto a narrow panel beside the core. Hidden locks opened with a shriek. A web of red light wrapped around their arms.

"Ex-Member!" Swiftwing dove from above, but a pulse burst from the console and knocked the bird sideways. Swiftwing crashed against the rail, feathers scattering.

The Ex-Member gritted their teeth. "The engine recognizes my old command pattern. I can hold the channel open."

"For how long?" Stoneback demanded. He pushed himself upright, one side of his shell still scarred from the dart corridor.

"Long enough if you stop asking."

The Cult Leader recovered and swept a metal rod across the platform. It struck Stoneback's shell with a clang that echoed through the chamber. Stoneback slid toward the edge. Thumper grabbed his foreleg and dug his heels into the grated floor.

"Thumper!" Stoneback barked. "The core!"

Thumper glanced at Slotholumule. The sloth had reached the central housing, but three mechanical arms unfolded around him. Their tips glowed red, searching for the core. One arm snapped shut inches from his face.

"I need a path!" Slotholumule called.

Thumper saw it then: a narrow strip of console between the rotating rings and the locked housing. Too narrow for Stoneback. Too dangerous for Swiftwing. But a rabbit could cross it.

"Make one!" Thumper shouted.

He released Stoneback and sprinted. The platform bucked beneath him as the engine's power surged. Heat rolled from the rings, drying his eyes. A mechanical arm swung down. Thumper slid beneath it, feeling its hot edge skim the fur along his back.

The Cult Leader seized his ears.

"You little nuisance," the human snarled.

Thumper kicked hard. The leader's grip loosened, and Thumper twisted free, landing against the console. His paws struck a row of raised switches. The chamber filled with a violent crackle.

"Thumper!" Wiseclaw shouted. "Not those!"

"I know!"

He did not know. He only knew the machine had begun charging again, and Slotholumule was trapped inside its arms. Thumper slammed his palm against the largest switch.

The console shutters dropped across one section of the platform. A barrier of copper plates rose between Slotholumule and the Cult Leader. The human's rod struck it, sending sparks over his shoulders.

"Good!" Slotholumule called. "Keep him away!"

The Cult Leader's face hardened. "You think a wall can stop history?"

"No," Slotholumule said. "But it can stop you."

He drove the glowing core into the housing.

The Voice Engine screamed.

Every ring halted at once. The sudden silence was worse than the noise. Then the chamber exploded into motion. The rings spun backward, dragging cables from the walls. Relay signals flashed across the glass panels, racing outward toward the crater and the forest beyond.

"Transmission interrupted," Wiseclaw said, staring at the recording crystal in his claws. "But the overload is spreading!"

A column of light punched through the center of the platform. It caught Stoneback and lifted him from the floor. Swiftwing beat against the current, unable to reach him.

"Hold on!" Thumper yelled.

Stoneback's claws scraped uselessly across the grating. Thumper lunged and caught the edge of his shell. The force pulled at both of them. His shoulders burned. Below, the platform had split open, revealing a shaft packed with turning gears.

The Ex-Member remained at the side panel, red light tightening around their arms. Their hood had fallen back. Sweat shone across their face.

"Get them clear!" they shouted.

Slotholumule looked over. "We leave together."

"You cannot."

"I said together!"

The Ex-Member turned toward him, and something in their expression stopped the sloth. Not surrender. Certainty.

"I helped build the lock," they said. "I know what it takes to break it."

The Cult Leader struck the copper barrier again. A crack spread across its surface.

"Ex-Member!" he bellowed. "You swore the Voice Engine would restore order!"

"I swore because you made truth dangerous," the Ex-Member answered. "I was wrong to help you make silence look like peace."

The barrier burst.

The Cult Leader charged. Slotholumule raised one arm to shield the core. The human's rod came down, but Ex-Member tore one hand from the panel and caught the rod in midair. Red light flared through their fingers.

The machine convulsed.

"Move!" Ex-Member shouted.

Slotholumule seized Thumper's wrist. Thumper still held Stoneback's shell with his other paw. Swiftwing swooped low, hooked Stoneback's harness, and pulled. Wiseclaw scrambled after them, clutching the recording crystal against his chest.

The Cult Leader fought against the Ex-Member's grip. "You will be erased!"

"No," said Ex-Member. "You will be heard."

They drove the captured rod into the control panel.

A blinding pulse tore across the platform. Thumper felt himself lifted, weightless, as cold air rushed beneath him. He saw the Cult Leader thrown backward. He saw Slotholumule wrap his body around the glowing core. He saw Ex-Member standing alone at the center of the red-lit machine, holding the channel open with both hands.

Then the platform slammed back into place.

Thumper landed hard beside Stoneback. Pain shot through his hip. The chamber rang with falling metal. One of the great rings had cracked, and molten lines crawled across its surface.

"Thumper!" Slotholumule shouted. "Are you hurt?"

"Later!" Thumper pushed himself up. "The core!"

Slotholumule was on one knee. The core pulsed in his hands, brighter than before. The housing around it had opened, exposing a black cavity lined with crystal teeth.

Wiseclaw stared into it. "That is the destruction window."

"How long?" Swiftwing asked.

Wiseclaw's eyes flicked to the crystal. "Until the next pulse? Seconds."

The Cult Leader rose through the smoke. His coat was torn, and blood marked his brow, but his hand still gripped the metal rod.

"You have no idea what you are destroying," he said. "Without my voice, the forest will fracture. Every creature will choose its own truth."

"Every creature already has a voice," Slotholumule replied.

The leader rushed him.

Thumper saw the attack coming. He sprang between them and slammed into the human's knees. The Cult Leader toppled, but his rod struck the floor. A shockwave burst outward. Thumper flew into the console rail, and the breath left his body.

Stoneback rolled over him, shell-first. The shockwave cracked against the turtle and broke around him.

"Stay down," Stoneback growled.

"I'm not staying anywhere."

Thumper crawled toward the housing. His hip screamed with every movement. Across the platform, Slotholumule struggled to hold the core steady while the machine pulled at it. The light had begun to turn white.

"Now!" Wiseclaw cried. "The window is open!"

Slotholumule thrust the core into the black cavity.

Nothing happened.

The rings continued to turn. The core remained intact, humming with trapped power.

“Why didn’t it break?” Swiftwing shouted.

Wiseclaw looked toward the side panel. The Ex-Member was still there, but the red light had climbed to their throat. Their knees trembled.

“The final lock is manual!” Wiseclaw said. “Someone has to hold the channel closed!”

The Cult Leader laughed from behind Stoneback. “And who will volunteer?”

The Ex-Member looked at Slotholumule.

Thumper understood before the others did. The ally had already chosen.

“No!” Slotholumule said. He pulled at the core. “There has to be another way!”

“There was,” Ex-Member answered. “Before I helped build this place.”

The red light reached their face. Their voice shook, but it did not break.

“Tell them what happened here.”

“We will,” Slotholumule said.

“Tell them I was part of it.”

“You can tell them yourself!”

The Ex-Member smiled sadly. “Then make the machine listen.”

They locked both hands around the panel and pulled.

The entire control center lurched. The red light snapped into a solid beam, pinning the Ex-Member to the console. The Voice Engine’s rings shrieked as their motion slowed. The black cavity opened wider.

"Destroy it!" Ex-Member cried.

Slotholumule pushed with everything he had.

Thumper staggered to his feet and ran toward the housing. He did not think about the heat or the broken floor. He thought of the market bell, the overturned cart, and all the voices the cult had tried to bury beneath its broadcasts.

He struck the core with both paws.

Stoneback added his weight. Swiftwing slammed into the side of the housing. Wiseclaw drove the recording crystal against a glowing seam.

The core cracked.

A thin line of darkness split its light.

The Cult Leader tore free and lunged toward them. Thumper turned, ready to meet him, but Slotholumule moved faster. The sloth caught the human's arm and held him back as the core broke apart.

A sound like a storm ripping through the earth filled the chamber.

The Voice Engine collapsed inward. Its rings shattered into bright fragments. Cables snapped from the walls, and the broadcast voices vanished in a rush of static. Far beyond the chamber, relay towers blinked out one by one.

The Cult Leader screamed as the last beam of power tore from his rod.

When the light faded, Thumper lay on the cracked platform with dust in his mouth. Stoneback's shell pressed against his side. Swiftwing was sprawled near the rail. Wiseclaw's recording crystal still glowed faintly between his claws.

Slotholumule stood beside the ruined housing, breathing hard.

Across the wreckage, the Ex-Member was gone beneath the fallen panel.

“Ex-Member?” Slotholumule called.

No answer came.

Thumper pushed himself upright. The chamber smelled of ash and hot stone. He stared at the place where their ally had stood, then at the broken machine.

“We got the window,” Wiseclaw whispered.

“Yes,” Slotholumule said.

His voice carried no triumph.

The Cult Leader lay powerless beside the dead console, while the forest’s real voices began returning through the remaining speakers: frightened calls, confused questions, and then the first clear cry from somewhere above.

“The broadcast stopped!”

Thumper reached for Slotholumule’s hand. The sloth took it, gripping gently.

Behind them, a final red light flickered beneath the wreckage.

Then it went dark.

CHAPTER 14

The Device Shatters, HQ Collapses

The red light beneath the wreckage blinked once, then the floor dropped.

Slotholumule tightened his grip on Thumper’s paw as stone burst upward around them. Dust filled his mouth. Somewhere behind the ruined Voice Engine, metal rings shrieked against one another, spinning without power, while the cavern ceiling groaned like a wounded animal.

“Move!” Swiftwing cried.

Slotholumule pulled Thumper toward the tunnel. His claws scraped across the floor as another tremor threw him against the wall. The device was destroyed. The cult’s broadcast had been cut off. Ex-Member had given everything to hold the channel open.

But none of that mattered if the base buried them alive.

“Everyone to the exit!” Slotholumule shouted. “Stay together!”

A slab of rock slammed down between them and Wiseclaw. The old turtle vanished behind a cloud of gray dust.

“Wiseclaw!”

“I’m here!” came the muffled reply. “The passage is blocked!”

Stoneback lumbered toward the fallen slab, one foreleg dragging from the dart corridor. His shell was scored with black-feather marks, and blood darkened the edge of one plate.

"Back away," Stoneback said.

He lowered his head and drove his shell into the rock.

The slab shifted a finger's width. Stoneback grunted, legs trembling.

"Again!" Thumper shouted.

Stoneback pushed harder. Cracks crawled through the ceiling above him. Pebbles struck his shell and bounced like rain on a roof.

Slotholumule looked at the tunnel ahead. It narrowed toward the crater exit, but smoke rolled through it from the collapsing machinery. The air tasted of hot copper. Behind them, the chamber holding the Voice Engine flashed blue, then orange.

"Stoneback, stop!" Slotholumule called. "The ceiling's coming down!"

"If I stop, Wiseclaw stays behind."

The turtle's voice was steady, but his injured leg buckled.

Slotholumule felt the old pull inside him - the command to rush forward, to solve everything with his own body, no matter who was crushed beneath the effort. He had carried that instinct through mountains, rivers, traps, and the cult's lies. It had brought him to the Voice Engine. It could also get his friends killed.

"Wiseclaw!" he called. "Can you move the slab from your side?"

"Not without the control panel. The emergency doors are sealed."

Swiftwing darted overhead, wings beating against the dust. "There's a maintenance shaft above the slab! Too narrow for Stoneback, but Thumper can fit."

Thumper's ears snapped upright. "I can open the door."

"And then?" Stoneback asked.

"And then we get Wiseclaw out," Slotholumule said. "Thumper, take the shaft. Swiftwing, guide him. Stoneback, hold the slab only until they clear it."

Stoneback gave a short nod.

Thumper sprang onto a broken console and disappeared through the square opening in the wall. His claws scratched against metal. A moment later, his voice echoed from above.

"It's jammed!"

"Use the red lever," Wiseclaw called. "Not the black one!"

"There are three red levers!"

"Then choose the one that isn't sparking!"

Thumper yanked one. Nothing happened. The tunnel shook again, and a seam split across the ceiling.

"Thumper!" Slotholumule shouted. "Now!"

"I'm trying!"

Stoneback's shoulders sagged. The slab began sliding back toward him.

Slotholumule shoved himself beneath its lower edge. Rock crushed his back. Dust coated his fur, and pain flashed down his arms.

"Slotholumule!" Thumper yelled.

"Open the door!"

"I can't!"

"You can," Slotholumule said through clenched teeth. "The cult built this place to make every voice sound certain. Don't listen to the fear. Listen to Wiseclaw."

The words were meant for Thumper, but they steadied Slotholumule too. Wiseclaw had spent years studying the cult's systems. Stoneback knew how to endure pressure. Swiftwing saw routes no one else could see. Thumper was quick enough to slip through a gap that would stop the rest of them.

No single creature could carry the escape.

Thumper pulled the middle lever.

A lock snapped open. The slab lifted three inches as hidden machinery groaned.

"Now!" Wiseclaw shouted.

Stoneback lunged forward. Slotholumule pushed with him. Wiseclaw crawled through the gap, clutching the recording crystal against his chest. His spectacles were cracked, and one side of his face was bleeding.

"Everyone out!" Slotholumule said.

They ran.

The tunnel buckled behind them. Stoneback's shell scraped the walls as he forced his way through the narrowing passage. Swiftwing flew ahead, calling back directions through the roar.

"Left turn! The right tunnel is flooded!"

Water burst from the right-hand wall, black with oil. It spread across the floor, carrying broken cables that spat blue sparks.

Thumper skidded to a stop. "The bridge is gone!"

Ahead, a metal walkway hung over a deep shaft. Half of it had collapsed, leaving a gap wide enough to swallow Stoneback. On the far side, a round door marked the crater exit. Beyond its seams, daylight showed in thin white lines.

Slotholumule stared at the gap. The exit was close enough to see, too far to reach.

A deep boom rolled through the base. The Voice Engine chamber collapsed. Heat surged down the tunnel.

"Stoneback can't jump that," Wiseclaw said.

"I can carry Thumper," Swiftwing said. "Maybe Wiseclaw."

"And Stoneback?" Thumper asked.

Stoneback looked at the broken walkway, then at the glowing water below. "Leave me."

"No," Slotholumule said.

Another section of ceiling fell behind them. The dust cloud swallowed the tunnel they had crossed.

Slotholumule searched the walls. Pipes. Brackets. A thick communications cable stretched across the shaft, still humming with the device's leftover charge. It was anchored to the far door.

"Swiftwing," he said, "can you reach that anchor?"

The bird followed his gaze. "I can cut it, but the cable may swing."

"Good. We'll use it as a line."

Wiseclaw shook his head. "It could carry current."

"It's already carrying current."

"That is not the same as being safe."

"Safe ended when the ceiling fell."

Slotholumule climbed onto the broken edge. Heat pressed against his face. He could smell scorched dust and wet stone. Behind him, Stoneback lowered himself, ready to

brace the cable.

"Swiftwing, wait for my signal."

The bird launched. She beat her wings hard, crossed the shaft, and landed beside the far anchor. Her beak struck the metal clamp once, twice. Sparks sprayed over her feathers.

"Now!" Slotholumule shouted.

Swiftwing tore the clamp free.

The cable whipped across the shaft. Stoneback caught it against his shell, but the force dragged him toward the edge. Slotholumule seized the cable with both hands.

"Thumper, go!"

The rabbit grabbed the line and swung. For one breath he hung above the shaft, legs kicking over the dark drop. Swiftwing caught his collar and hauled him onto the far platform.

"Wiseclaw!"

The turtle clutched the recording crystal beneath his chin and crossed next. The cable groaned under his weight. Stoneback held it steady, muscles shaking.

Slotholumule looked back at him. "Your turn."

Stoneback shook his head. "The line won't hold us both."

"It will."

"You don't know that."

"No," Slotholumule admitted. "But I know we're not leaving you."

Stoneback's eyes softened. "Then cross first."

The tunnel behind them collapsed with a thunderclap. A wave of dust slammed into Slotholumule's back. He nearly lost his grip.

Stoneback shoved him toward the cable.

Slotholumule swung across. The line burned through his palms. Below, the shaft filled with falling rock. He reached the far side, rolled onto the platform, and turned as Stoneback hooked one claw around the cable.

The turtle moved slowly. Too slowly.

The anchor shrieked.

"Stoneback!" Slotholumule reached out.

The cable tore free from the wall.

Stoneback dropped.

Slotholumule lunged and caught the edge of his shell. The impact nearly pulled him over. Wiseclaw seized Slotholumule's ankle. Thumper grabbed Wiseclaw. Swiftwing hooked her claws into the doorframe.

For a moment, the four of them formed a trembling chain above the shaft.

Stoneback's weight dragged at Slotholumule's arms. His injured leg struck the wall, and he grunted.

"Let go of me," Stoneback said.

"Not happening."

"The platform is breaking."

Stoneback was right. Cracks spread beneath Slotholumule's chest. The metal bent downward.

"Pull!" Slotholumule roared.

They pulled together. Stoneback rose an inch, then another. Slotholumule's shoulders burned. The edge cut into his ribs.

A pulse of blue light flashed through the shaft.

The loose cable had fallen into the water.

Electricity raced across the black surface.

"Up!" Wiseclaw shouted.

Slotholumule hauled with everything left in him. Stoneback's front half cleared the edge. Thumper caught one of his claws and pulled. Swiftwing beat her wings against the turtle's face, pushing him toward safety.

They rolled away as the platform gave way.

The metal walkway collapsed into the electrified shaft. The blast threw them against the exit door. Stoneback landed hard, his shell cracking against the frame.

Slotholumule crawled to him. "Stoneback?"

The turtle opened one eye. "Still here."

Relief loosened something in Slotholumule's chest, but the door remained sealed.

Wiseclaw pushed himself upright and examined the control panel. "The emergency release has no power."

"Then break it," Thumper said.

"It is reinforced."

Slotholumule looked through the narrow window. Beyond the door lay the crater slope, washed in pale morning light. The Flat Earth HQ banner snapped above the rim, its

cloth torn but still visible.

The base shuddered again.

Slotholumule stepped toward the panel. His palms were burned from the cable. His limbs felt heavy, but the door was between his team and open air.

He drove his shoulder into it.

The panel sparked.

He struck it again.

"Slotholumule," Wiseclaw warned, "the frame may collapse."

"Then we move before it does."

He struck a third time. The panel split. Wires spilled out, glowing red and white. Slotholumule wrapped his claws around the largest bundle and pulled.

The door groaned open.

Cold crater air rushed over them, carrying the smell of rain, pine, and scorched earth. Swiftwing flew through first. Thumper followed. Wiseclaw crawled after her. Stoneback squeezed through with Slotholumule pushing from behind.

They spilled onto the rocky slope just as the tunnel mouth folded inward.

The ground rolled beneath them. The crater wall cracked from rim to floor. The Flat Earth HQ banner tore loose and vanished into a cloud of dust.

Slotholumule rose onto his knees, coughing. Around him, the others struggled to stand. Stoneback lay on his side, breathing hard. Wiseclaw held the recording crystal close, its inner light still flickering.

For one fragile moment, there was only wind.

Then a voice whispered from the broken relay tower.

“Attention, forest citizens.”

Slotholumule froze.

The tower’s speaker was cracked, its wires hanging loose, yet the Cult Leader’s stern voice carried across the crater.

“Flat Earth HQ has suffered an unfortunate attack by violent saboteurs. The truth remains secure. The forest must reject their false heroes.”

Thumper’s ears flattened. “But the device is gone.”

Wiseclaw stared at the tower. “Not all the relays.”

The voice changed. Beneath the Cult Leader’s words came fragments of other broadcasts - market bells, frightened cries, Slotholumule’s own promise of 4M FACE twisted into an accusation.

Stoneback pushed himself upright. “They’re still speaking.”

Slotholumule looked at the collapsed base, the torn banner, and the pale forest beyond the crater. They had destroyed the machine that could rewrite every message. They had escaped alive.

But the cult’s echoes were already moving through the world.

He reached for the recording crystal. Wiseclaw placed it in his burned hands.

“Then we answer,” Slotholumule said.

The relay tower crackled again, spreading the lie toward the distant trees.

Slotholumule turned from the wreckage and faced the northern trail. Behind him, the crater continued to settle. Ahead, the forest waited beneath a sky the cult had failed to control completely.

"Together," he said.

And with Stoneback limping beside him, the team began the climb out of the crater while the stolen voice followed them into the morning.



Peace Returns, Shadows Stay

The first clean birdsong reached Swiftwing before the forest did.

She stood on a blackened ridge above the crater, wings tucked tight against the cold morning, while smoke slid from the broken tunnels below. The Flat Earth HQ banner had fallen during the collapse. Its torn edge dragged over the rocks like a dead flag.

Behind her, Thumper laughed too loudly.

“We’re out,” the rabbit said. “We’re actually out.”

Stoneback lowered himself beside a cedar, one leg trembling beneath his shell. Wiseclaw checked the recording crystal for the third time. Slotholumule sat on a flat stone, his 4M FACE shirt gray with ash, one paw pressed against his ribs.

Swiftwing watched him breathe.

The stolen voice from the Voice Engine still seemed to cling to the air. It had followed them up the crater, whispering false accounts of their retreat, turning sacrifice into cowardice and courage into crime. Now the machine was buried. The Ex-Member was gone. The Cult Leader had vanished into the collapse.

The forest should have sounded free.

Instead, a thin metallic chirp rose from the trees.

Swiftwing’s head snapped toward it.

"What?" Thumper asked.

She lifted one wing. "Quiet."

The others fell silent. Wind moved through the pines. Water dripped from a cracked ledge. Then the chirp came again, farther east, followed by a faint pulse of blue light between the trunks.

Wiseclaw tightened his grip on the recording crystal. "That isn't natural."

"No," Swiftwing said. "And it isn't from the crater."

Slotholumule pushed himself upright. "Can you reach it?"

"I can reach anything that shows itself."

"Then find out what it is," he said. "Before we celebrate."

The words landed harder than she expected. Swiftwing had been waiting for permission to fly since the team escaped. She wanted distance from the smoke, from the broken machine, from the last sight of the Ex-Member gripping the channel open while the others ran. She wanted one clear answer: the threat was over.

She launched from the ridge.

Cold air tore beneath her wings. From above, the forest edge looked almost peaceful. The crater was a dark wound among the trees, its sides scattered with metal and stone. Farther out, morning sunlight touched the market paths and the river bends. Creatures would soon come from their burrows and nests, carrying rumors of victory.

Then Swiftwing saw the watchers.

Three figures stood beyond the eastern tree line. They were too far away for faces, wrapped in dull coats that broke up their shapes. One held a narrow device against the light. Another raised an arm, and a signal flashed toward the hills.

Swiftwing banked sharply.

The figures scattered.

She dove after the one nearest the creek, but branches snapped upward around her. A net sprang from the undergrowth, its cords strung with tiny metal bells. Swiftwing twisted, clipped one wingtip, and plunged into the wet leaves. Bells shrilled across the forest.

By the time she rose, the watcher had disappeared.

A black-feathered dart quivered in the tree beside her. Its white circle caught the sun.

Swiftwing pulled it free. The shaft was warm.

She carried it back to the ridge.

Thumper's ears flattened when she saw the dart. "Cult hunters?"

"Maybe," Swiftwing said. "But they weren't moving like the patrols we saw underground."

Wiseclaw examined the white circle through a small lens. "This mark appeared on several relay housings. The cult used it to identify their own equipment."

"Then the cult survived," Stoneback said.

"No." Slotholumule looked toward the trees. "A surviving cult is one problem. A cult with friends is another."

The others turned to him.

Swiftwing felt the morning chill vanish beneath her feathers. "There were three watchers. They split when I pursued one. That means they knew the ground."

"And they knew you were coming," Wiseclaw said.

Slotholumule stepped closer to the edge. "We need a signal source."

"I'll find it."

His gaze settled on her. It was tired, but steady. "Don't chase them alone."

"I'm faster alone."

"That isn't the same as being safe."

The words struck a private bruise. Swiftwing glanced at the crater. The Ex-Member had stayed behind so the team could live. Stoneback had limped through falling rock. Slotholumule had carried the glowing core while the Cult Leader lunged for him.

She had flown ahead.

She had seen the danger and failed to stop it.

"I'm not asking to be safe," she said. "I'm asking to know whether we're still being hunted."

Slotholumule's expression softened. "Then take Wiseclaw."

Wiseclaw blinked. "I am standing right here."

"Exactly," Thumper muttered. "Hard to lose."

They followed the creek east. Stoneback remained at the ridge with Thumper and Slotholumule, guarding the recording crystal and watching the crater. Swiftwing moved from branch to branch while Wiseclaw picked his way along the muddy bank.

The signal returned every forty heartbeats.

Chirp.

Blue pulse.

Silence.

Wiseclaw stopped beside a fallen birch. "There."

A small metal box had been wedged beneath the roots. Its surface bore no cult banner, only a pale circle cut through by three short lines.

Swiftwing crouched beside it. "Can you open it?"

"I can try."

"Try faster."

He gave her a sharp look. "Fear makes poor hands."

"So does patience."

"Patience keeps hands attached."

The box clicked before either of them touched it.

A voice spilled from its grille.

"Relay seven is dark. Crater command is silent. Begin secondary observation."

Swiftwing froze.

The voice was not the Cult Leader's. It was calm, almost bored, and carried no trace of the feverish certainty that had filled the Voice Engine.

Wiseclaw leaned close. "It's receiving, not transmitting."

A second voice answered through a burst of static. "Do we recover the crystal?"

Swiftwing's claws tightened against the bark.

"Negative. Let the activists carry it. Public exposure will draw the forest's attention to the crater."

Wiseclaw's face paled beneath his feathers. "They know about the recording."

The box crackled again.

"Phase Two proceeds at the northern stations. No central leader is to be named."

Then the signal died.

For a moment, only the creek moved.

Swiftwing stared at the dark grille. Her first thought was to tear it apart. Her second was to fly north immediately. Her third, quieter thought was that the watchers had wanted them to find this.

"Phase Two," Wiseclaw said. "That implies preparation beyond the crater."

"It implies a trap."

"Both can be true."

Swiftwing seized the box and lifted it from the roots. A wire stretched beneath the mud. The moment it came free, the forest flashed white.

A distant boom rolled through the hills.

Birds burst from the canopy in a black cloud.

Swiftwing looked back toward the ridge. Smoke climbed there now, thin and gray.

"They found the others," she said.

She launched before Wiseclaw could answer.

The flight back was a blur of branches and cold air. At the ridge, Slotholumule stood with Thumper in front of Stoneback. The crater's eastern slope had erupted, throwing dirt across the trees. No one was injured, but the celebration had vanished from every face.

Thumper pointed at the smoke. "That came from an old relay trench."

Wiseclaw landed hard beside them. "The watchers were using a hidden network. They mentioned northern stations and a Phase Two."

Slotholumule took the metal box from Swiftwing. He turned it over, studying the unfamiliar mark.

"Did you hear a leader?" he asked.

"No," Swiftwing said. "They refused to name one."

Stoneback's damaged leg shook as he rose. "Then we expose the Cult Leader and follow the chain."

"The chain may not have a head," Wiseclaw said. "It may be a web."

Slotholumule looked toward the forest, where the watchers had vanished. "A web can still catch people."

"And cut them," Swiftwing said.

He met her eyes. "What happened out there?"

She wanted to say nothing. She wanted to say the watchers had escaped because she had been too slow, that the net had rung like an alarm, that she had chased a shape instead of protecting the team.

"I found the box," she said. "They let me find it."

Slotholumule nodded once. "Then we don't give them what they expect."

"What do they expect?" Thumper asked.

"That we rush north angry and tired."

Swiftwing looked at the crater. The broken banner stirred below them. Somewhere under the rubble, the Voice Engine's last glow faded into stone.

She had wanted certainty. Instead, she had brought back a warning.

"We should leave before they place another relay," she said.

"Where?" Stoneback asked.

Swiftwing turned toward the northern trees. Between the trunks, far beyond the creek, a tiny blue pulse blinked once.

Then another answered from the west.

A third glimmered on the ridge behind them.

The signals formed a wide triangle around the crater.

Wiseclaw whispered, "That isn't a patrol."

"No," Swiftwing said.

Slotholumule closed his paw around the metal box. "It's a map."

The team stood among the ash and torn branches while the forest brightened around them. No leader appeared. No army marched from the trees. Only the distant watchers remained, hidden beyond sight, passing their silent light from station to station.

The crater was quiet.

The conspiracy was not.

A Statue for the Smallest Hero

The first hammer strike rang across the forest common ground before sunrise, startling a flock of Sparrows from the cedar roof. Slotholumule looked up as they scattered, their wings flashing silver in the pale light, then tightened his grip around the folded cloth bearing the 4M FACE promise.

“Again,” called Thumper.

The rabbit swung. Stone chips jumped from the block beneath his paws.

Slotholumule moved toward him, the damp grass brushing his ankles. The statue’s base stood in the center of the clearing, marked in charcoal with a rough outline of a small turtle shell. Around it, animals gathered in uneasy clusters. Some carried flowers. Others carried tools. A few watched from behind tree trunks, their eyes fixed on the northern trail.

Peace had returned, but it had not made anyone careless.

“We need the stone ready before the gathering,” Slotholumule said. “No speeches until the names are carved.”

Thumper lowered the hammer. “Stoneback’s name is the only one that belongs there.”

The words struck harder than the tool.

Slotholumule looked at the block. The pale stone was too large for the clearing and too heavy for the team to move without help. It had come from the mountain road, where Stoneback had limped beside them after the Voice Engine collapsed. Every old

scratch on Stoneback's shell had shone beneath the crater's floodlights. He had kept walking anyway.

"He belongs there," Slotholumule said. "But not alone."

Thumper's ears snapped forward. "He gave everything so we could get out. Why make his sacrifice into a crowd?"

"Because he never fought for a single name."

A sharp whistle cut through the clearing. Swiftwing dropped from a low branch and landed on the statue's unfinished shoulder. Dust trembled beneath her claws.

"Three watchers on the north ridge," she said. "Maybe four. They disappear whenever I circle back."

The animals murmured. A badger near the tool pile pulled a young fox behind him.

Slotholumule felt the old pull in his chest - the urge to climb, search, confront. The forest had barely stopped flinching at every distant crack. If watchers were studying the common ground, the statue might become a target before its first stone was set.

"Can you identify them?" he asked.

"No. Gray Hare tracks, but no Gray Hare." Swiftwing brushed grit from one wing. "A black-feathered dart was wedged in the ridge bark. The white circle was painted over."

Wiseclaw arrived with the recording crystal tucked beneath one arm. The turtle's steps were slow, but his eyes were bright and watchful.

"Paint can hide a mark," Wiseclaw said. "It cannot erase a habit."

"Did the signal box speak?" Slotholumule asked.

Wiseclaw shook his head. "Only static. Whoever is watching knows how to stay quiet."

A child's voice rose from the crowd. "Then why build the statue?"

The question came from a small squirrel standing beside a basket of white stones. Her tail trembled, though she tried to hold it still.

Slotholumule crouched until they were eye to eye. "Because fear does not get to choose what we remember."

"Will it keep them away?"

"No," he said.

The squirrel's ears drooped.

"But it will tell us what they cannot change."

Behind him, Thumper set down the hammer with a hard clack. "That sounds like a speech."

"It sounds like the truth," Wiseclaw said.

A rustle passed through the crowd. More animals entered the common ground: Rabbit carrying planks, Roost with a bundle of rope, Perry the Possum dragging a sack of nails. Perry stopped when he saw the unfinished block.

His face went pale.

Slotholumule noticed. "Perry?"

Perry's paws tightened around the rope. "I saw a carving like that beneath the crater. The cult used it to mark a memory vault."

Thumper stepped between Perry and the statue. "This is not their vault."

"I know." Perry swallowed. "That is what worries me. Someone may think the statue is a signal."

Swiftwing lifted her head. "To whom?"

Perry looked toward the northern ridge. "To the people who were listening after the Voice Engine broke."

The common ground seemed to shrink around them. Hammers stopped. Rope slid from Roost's claws. Somewhere near the creek, water tapped steadily against a fallen branch.

Slotholumule wanted to promise that the watchers would be found. He wanted to send Swiftwing over the ridge, Wiseclaw into the old relay tunnels, and every able creature after them until the hidden network gave up its names.

Instead, he looked at the animals gathered around the stone.

"If we stop now," he said, "they decide what our silence means."

A voice from the crowd answered, "And if we continue?"

"Then we build where everyone can see us."

The badger frowned. "That makes us a target."

"We already are," Slotholumule said. "The difference is whether we stand alone."

For a moment, no one moved.

Then Stoneback's former walking stick struck the ground. Wiseclaw had carried it from the crater, its tip blackened from the collapse.

"Set the first stone," the turtle said.

Thumper picked up the hammer.

The blow landed. Stone cracked with a clean, bright sound.

Animals came forward. Rabbit braced the base while Roost tied the lifting rope. Perry hammered nails into a wooden frame. Children carried pebbles in both paws. Even those who had doubted Slotholumule joined the work, though some kept glancing toward the ridge.

The statue slowly took shape beneath their hands.

They carved Stoneback first: the broad shell, the steady feet, the slight tilt of his head as if he were listening for danger beyond the trees. Slotholumule guided the chisel, but he let Thumper make the deepest cuts.

"He should look stubborn," Thumper said.

"He was stubborn."

"He should look kind, too."

"Then carve both."

Thumper's paw paused. "I don't know how."

Slotholumule placed his hand over the rabbit's. Together, they pressed the chisel into the stone.

"Like this."

The line curved beneath the rough face. Not a smile exactly, but the beginning of one.

By midday, the common ground had become a living workshop. The forest's old market bell hung from a fresh beam, its crack still visible along the rim. Wiseclaw set the recording crystal on a stump, and Stoneback's voice played through the clearing - rough, calm, and unmistakably alive in memory.

"Leave no one behind."

Several animals bowed their heads.

Slotholumule closed his eyes. For one breath, he was back beneath the crater, surrounded by falling rock and the dying pulse of the Voice Engine. He saw the Ex-Member at the channel, holding it open while the others reached the controls. He heard Thumper's hand find his. He remembered the red light blinking beneath the wreckage.

When the recording ended, the silence was not empty.

A young bird stepped forward. "Can we put those words on the statue?"

Wiseclaw looked at Slotholumule.

The question carried more weight than the stone. A statue could honor Stoneback, but it could also turn the movement into a single image, a single leader, a single story easy for enemies to twist.

Slotholumule unfolded the 4M FACE cloth and laid it across the statue's unfinished base.

"Put the words around him," he said. "Not beneath him."

Thumper smiled faintly. "So the whole forest has to hold them up."

"So the whole forest owns them."

The crowd began to carve.

By late afternoon, the statue stood waist-high, its shell catching the amber light. It was unfinished, uneven, and beautiful. At its base, creatures pressed their names into wet clay - not as followers, but as witnesses.

Then Swiftwing cried out.

A black dart struck the wooden beam above the market bell.

The bell shuddered. Its cracked note rolled across the clearing.

Panic broke the circle. Animals grabbed children, tools, baskets. Roost flung the rope aside and spread his wings. Wiseclaw shoved the recording crystal beneath his shell.

“North ridge!” Swiftwing shouted. “They’re moving!”

Slotholumule climbed onto the statue’s base. Beyond the trees, branches snapped in a line leading toward the common ground. Not one watcher. Several.

“Stay together!” he called. “No one runs into the forest alone!”

A second dart struck the stone beside his hand. The mark was painted over, but beneath the gray coating the white circle showed through.

The crowd surged backward.

Slotholumule saw the fear in their faces and understood the trap. The watchers did not need to attack. They only needed to make the forest believe that gathering was dangerous.

He stepped down from the statue and planted himself between the stone and the northern trail.

“Swiftwing, keep them visible,” he said. “Roost, get the children behind the cedar wall. Thumper, take the east path. No pursuit.”

Thumper’s ears flattened. “We can catch them.”

“Not today.”

“Then they leave knowing they frightened us.”

“They leave knowing we protected each other.”

The rabbit stared at him, angry and grieving. Then he nodded and led the younger animals away.

Swiftwing rose into the air. Her wings beat hard enough to scatter dust from the statue. She called directions from above, never diving, never losing sight of the moving branches.

"There - two by the fallen birch!"

Roost joined her, circling wide. The watchers retreated. Their faces remained hidden, but one wore a strip of dark cloth tied around an arm. Another carried a metal box that flashed once between the leaves.

Wiseclaw emerged from behind the cedar wall. "That box is a relay."

"Can you reach it?"

"Not without following them."

The metal box vanished into the trees.

A third dart struck the ground at Slotholumule's feet.

He looked down. A narrow strip of paper had been tied beneath its feathers. He pulled it free.

Only three words were written there.

WE SEE YOU BUILD.

The forest waited for his reaction.

Slotholumule folded the message and tucked it inside his shirt, beneath the 4M FACE cloth. His claws felt cold.

"Finish the statue," he said.

Thumper stared at him. "Now?"

"Especially now."

The animals returned slowly. No one pretended the danger had passed. The ridge remained quiet, and the hidden relay had carried its warning into the trees. But Rabbit brought the hammer back. Perry reset the ropes. Wiseclaw placed the recording crystal on the stump again.

As evening settled, the first carved letters appeared around Stoneback's shell.

LEAVE NO ONE BEHIND.

Slotholumule stood before the unfinished statue while the last sunlight burned along its edges. The forest had given him gratitude, trust, and a place in its memory. It had also given him a larger burden. Every eye turned toward him now, waiting for courage to look simple.

He rested one hand against the stone.

"Stoneback," he whispered, "we'll make room for everyone."

From the northern ridge came a faint metallic click.

Slotholumule lifted his gaze.

The statue project had begun. The crowd had chosen to remain. But beyond the trees, unseen watchers were already carrying the forest's new symbol toward whatever waited next.



The Mechanical Bird Delivers Warning

Slotholumule pressed his palm against the unfinished statue's wooden base before the morning crowd could see him there. Sawdust clung to his fur. Beyond the clearing, hammers tapped in a steady rhythm, shaping Stoneback's memorial from cedar rescued after the crater collapse.

He should have been listening to the forest's hopeful noise. Instead, the cold metal in his other hand burned through his fingers.

The mechanical bird had fallen from the canopy without a sound. Its brass wings were folded tight, its glass eyes dark, and a strip of black paper was locked beneath its beak. A white circle marked the paper - the same symbol once stamped on a cult dart.

Slotholumule turned toward the sanctuary.

Dense leaves closed behind him as he climbed the familiar roots and slipped beneath the hanging vines. The sanctuary smelled of wet bark, crushed fern, and the smoke from last night's small fire. Here, at least, the hammers became distant. He set the bird on a flat stone and reached for the paper.

A spring clicked.

The bird's head snapped toward him.

"Easy," Slotholumule murmured.

Its wings shuddered. A thin voice spilled from somewhere inside its chest, broken by static.

"Four marks. One face. Beneath the place where no path is drawn."

The message stopped.

Slotholumule stared at the bird. The words were plain enough to be dangerous, but they offered no direction. Four marks could mean the painted 4M FACE on his shirt. It could mean four stations, four witnesses, four lies. The final phrase seemed designed to pull him toward a blank space on a map.

The bird opened its beak again.

"Seek the deeper truth."

Then its glass eyes flashed red.

Slotholumule lunged. He caught the bird just as a sharp pulse snapped through its frame. Heat stung his palm. The paper curled, releasing the bitter smell of burned oil.

He dropped it onto the stone and smothered the ember with a strip of moss.

A branch cracked outside.

Slotholumule froze.

"Slotholumule?" Swiftwing called from beyond the vines. "I saw the flash."

He tucked the bird beneath his shirt and moved toward the entrance. Swiftwing swept in, feathers damp with mist, a recording crystal tied beneath one wing. Her eyes went straight to his clenched hand.

"What did it say?"

"Something meant to be overheard," he replied.

"That is not an answer."

"No. It is a warning."

Swiftwing tilted her head. "From the cult?"

"The symbol says so. The message may not."

She hopped onto a root and peered at the singed paper. "You are hiding the rest."

"I am trying to understand it before I send everyone chasing a trap."

"After the crater, after the Voice Engine, after Ex-Member gave everything to stop that broadcast, we do not have the luxury of waiting for perfect meaning."

The name struck him harder than the pulse from the bird. He remembered Ex-Member's cloak vanishing behind the closing machinery, remembered the metal doors sealing while the global communications device screamed. The forest had survived because someone had chosen to stay behind.

Slotholumule placed the bird on the root between them.

"I need to know what it wants us to find," he said. "Not merely where it wants us to go."

Swiftwing's beak tightened. "Then let us find out before it sends another one."

She tapped the bird with one claw. Its brass shell gave a hollow tick.

Slotholumule examined the joints. The craft was finer than any device recovered from Flat Earth HQ. Its wing hinges were made from dark alloy, and tiny grooves ran along its breast in four curved lines. He rubbed soot from the metal.

The lines shifted.

They were not marks. They were paths.

He rotated the bird. The grooves formed a circle broken at four points, but one opening was wider than the others. At the center sat a shallow indentation shaped like an eye.

"An eye," Swiftwing said.

"Or a crater."

"Every symbol the cult used tried to make one answer look like the only answer."

Slotholumule lifted the bird close to his ear. A faint ticking came from inside. Not a clock. A repeated transmission.

He placed the recording crystal beside it. Wiseclaw had built the crystal to preserve the cult's stolen broadcasts, and its surface still held a pale blue glow. When Slotholumule touched the crystal's edge, the sanctuary filled with overlapping voices.

The Cult Leader spoke first, stern and clean.

"Truth belongs to those with the machinery to deliver it."

Perry the Possum answered beneath him, hurried and nervous.

"Then the northern relays must remain hidden."

Another voice whispered a sequence of tones. The mechanical bird answered with the same sequence.

Swiftwing's wings lifted. "That is not from the crater."

"No," Slotholumule said. "The rhythm is different."

He slowed the crystal's playback by pressing two claws against its face. The voices stretched into groans. Behind them, a faint sound emerged: wind rushing through hollow trunks, followed by three low knocks.

The bird's breast opened.

A narrow strip of silver bark slid out.

Slotholumule caught it before it touched the ground. Lines had been etched across the bark, too fine to see until he held it beneath a shaft of green light. The marks showed a river splitting around a black ridge. Beyond the ridge, four circles surrounded a single white eye.

Swiftwing leaned closer. "That is not on any route we traveled."

"It is not on any map."

"Then the message has failed."

"Or succeeded."

A rustle sounded outside. This time it came from the lower trail.

Swiftwing darted to the entrance and vanished into the leaves. Slotholumule folded the silver bark into his shirt and followed, moving as quietly as a sloth could through the roots.

Thumper stood below the sanctuary, ears angled toward the trees. Stoneback waited beside him, one leg still stiff from the climb out of the crater. Wiseclaw held a bundle of fresh boards for the statue. The clearing's distant hammering had stopped.

"What happened?" Thumper asked.

Slotholumule looked past him. No watcher showed between the trunks, but a faint metallic whirl drifted from the northern ridge.

"The bird delivered a message," he said.

Stoneback's expression hardened. "Another cult signal?"

"Possibly."

Wiseclaw adjusted the boards in his arms. "The symbol?"

Slotholumule showed them the singed paper. The white circle seemed brighter against the blackened edge.

Stoneback touched the mark with one claw. "That was on the darts in the tunnel."

"And on the relay box," Swiftwing said. "The one we found after the crater fell."

Thumper's ears flattened. "So the cult is still watching."

"Someone is," Slotholumule said. "But the message points beyond Flat Earth HQ."

Wiseclaw studied the silver bark when Slotholumule revealed it. His eyes narrowed behind his round lenses.

"This ridge is the northern boundary," he said. "I have seen old references to it in forest records. No confirmed trail continues past the split river."

"Why not?" Thumper asked.

"Because the records end there."

Stoneback gave a dry laugh. "Records do not simply end."

"These did," Wiseclaw replied. "Every copy. Every survey. The same missing stretch."

A second mechanical whir rose from the canopy.

Swiftwing sprang upward. "Down!"

A brass bird burst through the leaves, trailing a thread of smoke. Slotholumule reached for it, but it veered away and struck the memorial's unfinished base. The cedar cracked. Stoneback shoved Thumper aside as the bird ricocheted into the mud.

For one breath, nobody moved.

Then the bird's beak opened.

"Four marks. One face."

Slotholumule seized it. The machine bit into his glove with a needle hidden beneath its jaw. He flung it against a tree. Its wings tore loose, but the message continued.

"Beneath the place where no path is drawn."

The forest answered with a distant boom.

Not thunder. A signal.

Across the clearing, the northern ridge flashed once between the trees.

Swiftwing landed hard beside him. "That was a beacon."

"Can you track it?"

"I can track the next one."

Wiseclaw looked toward the unfinished statue. "And the memorial?"

Slotholumule felt the cracked cedar beneath his hand. Stoneback had nearly fallen protecting the others. The forest had barely begun to trust a symbol of resistance, and already someone had tried to break it.

"Finish the statue," he said. "Move the gathering deeper into the clearing. No one travels north until we know what waits there."

Stoneback stared at him. "You are going."

"Yes."

"Then I am going too."

"You are still injured."

"I was injured at the crater. I am not made of glass."

Thumper stepped forward. "Neither am I."

Swiftwing spread her wings. "And I can see the route from above."

Wiseclaw sighed, but his grip tightened around the boards. "Then we take the recording crystal. If this is another attempt to rewrite the truth, we bring evidence back."

Slotholumule looked at each of them. The sanctuary no longer felt private. The message had pushed its way through the vines, into the memorial, into the space between victory and the next fight.

He opened the silver bark again.

The etched river bent north, beyond the last known trail. At its center, beneath the white eye, four tiny words had appeared as the light shifted.

DEEPER THAN THE CRATER.

A chill moved through him despite the warm air.

The crater had held the Voice Engine, the Cult Leader's command, and the device that had twisted every message in the forest. But this map suggested something older, farther away, hidden where no path had been drawn.

Swiftwing watched his face. "What does it say?"

Slotholumule folded the bark.

"It points to an uncharted territory," he said. "North of the split river."

Behind them, the half-built statue creaked in the wind. Far above, another mechanical bird answered from the canopy.

This time, Slotholumule did not wait for it to descend.

He stepped onto the northern trail, and the others followed as the forest closed around them.

CHAPTER 18

The Uncharted Territory Map

“Slow down, Slotholumule,” Stoneback called. “The northern trail is already trying to swallow us.”

“I’m not stopping,” Slotholumule answered from ahead. “Not while the message still points beyond the ridge.”

Stoneback pushed through a curtain of wet fern, his shell scraping bark. Behind him, Thumper’s paws thudded softly over the roots, Swiftwing cut between the branches, and Wiseclaw kept the mechanical bird tucked beneath one wing. The forest had closed around them exactly as it had promised. Familiar trunks disappeared behind curtains of moss. The air smelled of rain, crushed leaves, and something metallic drifting from the north.

Stoneback wanted one thing before they went farther: proof that the message’s symbols described a real place rather than another cult trap.

The mechanical bird had carried four marks beneath its wing: a split circle, three crooked lines, a black star, and a pale notch shaped like a tooth. They had no reliable map of the northern forest. The old trails ended at the ridge, and every landmark beyond it had been left blank, as if the forest itself had been erased.

Stoneback did not trust blank spaces.

They climbed until the trees thinned around a shelf of stone. From the hidden overlook, the forest spread below in layers of green and gray. The southern paths curled toward the crater, where the Flat Earth HQ banner was no more than a dark

thread against the distant rock. To the north, mist filled a deep valley. Something moved beneath it - water, perhaps, or a road no map had remembered.

Slotholumule unfolded the stolen map across the stone. Its corners snapped in the wind. The 4M FACE slogan on his shirt flashed bright against the dim overlook.

"Here," Wiseclaw said, tapping the first mark. "The split circle matches the ridge."

"Or it marks the crater," Thumper said. "The cult loves circles."

Stoneback lowered his head until his eyes were level with the map. "Not this one. Look at the break. It faces west."

Swiftwing landed beside him, feathers slick with rain. "West is the old lightning scar."

Stoneback felt a small spark of certainty. "And the three crooked lines?"

He turned from the map and studied the valley. Three narrow streams descended through the mist, running side by side before vanishing behind a wall of pine. He remembered hearing them during the climb, not as separate rivers but as one deep, restless roar.

"Those are watercourses," he said. "They meet below the ridge."

Thumper leaned over the edge. Pebbles clicked down into the fog and did not reach bottom. "That valley isn't on any trail."

"That is why the cult hid it," Wiseclaw murmured.

Stoneback looked at him. "We do not know that."

Wiseclaw's claws tightened around the mechanical bird. "We know the message came marked with their symbol. We know watchers carried the statue's image north. We know the relay box near the crater was still warm. How many coincidences can a forest hold?"

A gust struck the overlook. The map skittered toward the drop.

Stoneback lunged, catching one corner beneath his forefoot. The paper tore with a sharp rip. Beneath the painted surface, a second layer gleamed - thin wax, pressed with lines too fine to see from a distance.

"Hold it," Stoneback said.

Slotholumule pinned the opposite edge. Thumper braced the map with both paws while Swiftwing shielded it from the wind. Stoneback scraped mud from the wax with the edge of a claw. A hidden route emerged, pale and angular, running from the ridge toward the three streams.

At its end sat the black star.

"The map was folded over itself," Stoneback said. "The clue was underneath."

"Can you read the route?" Slotholumule asked.

Stoneback traced the line. It crossed the valley, followed the middle stream, then turned sharply toward the tooth-shaped notch.

"No reliable reference," he said. "But the land confirms the first half."

"And the rest?" Thumper asked.

Stoneback looked north. The mist shifted, revealing a dark wall of cliffs. Near its base, a narrow opening appeared and vanished again.

The black star had not marked a destination. It marked a cave.

A cry sliced through the trees.

Swiftwing sprang upward. "Movement on the eastern slope!"

Stoneback heard it then: the dry snap of a twig, followed by another. Not deer. Too measured. Too many.

Slotholumule rolled the map tight. "We leave now."

"Toward the cave?" Wiseclaw asked.

"Toward the only place the cult does not want us to find."

Stoneback's stomach tightened. The route might be real, but the watchers had likely seen them reach the overlook. He wanted time to compare the streams, inspect the cliff, and make certain the symbols were not bait. Instead, the forest gave him seconds.

A black-feathered dart struck the stone where his head had been.

Stoneback dropped flat. Another dart hissed over his shell and buried itself in a pine. The white circle painted on its shaft gleamed through the rain.

"Down!" Slotholumule shouted.

Thumper kicked loose stones over the eastern edge. They rattled into the valley, drawing a burst of answering movement. Swiftwing wheeled through the rain, then dove behind a stand of firs.

"Three on the ridge," Swiftwing called. "Maybe more below!"

Stoneback pressed against the rock. The old scratches on his shell burned where the dart had grazed him. He stared at the map clutched in Slotholumule's hands. The hidden line ran beneath the tear like a vein.

"We cannot take the main descent," Stoneback said. "They will cut us off."

"Then find another," Slotholumule replied.

Stoneback turned toward the cliff face. Rain streamed over gray stone. The three streams vanished at its base, but the water's sound came from two places: the valley below and a hollow echo close by.

He crawled along the shelf, feeling the stone with his forefeet. At the edge of a moss bank, the rock gave a faint, hollow thrum.

"Here."

Thumper dug beside him. Roots tore free, releasing cold mud and the smell of underground water. Beneath the roots lay a narrow crack, barely wide enough for Thumper's shoulders.

Wiseclaw peered into it. "That is not on the map."

"It is," Stoneback said. He pointed to the pale notch at the end of the hidden route. "The tooth is a split entrance. The stream passes behind the cliff."

A dart struck the moss beside Wiseclaw's beak.

Slotholumule seized the root curtain and pulled. The opening widened with a groan of stone. "Stoneback first."

Stoneback hesitated. The crack descended into darkness. Water whispered below, and the air carried a bitter oil scent like the one that had clung to the cult's relay box.

The route was real.

So was the danger.

He tucked his limbs close and slid into the passage. Rock scraped his shell. Cold water rose around him, soaking his underside. Behind him, Thumper grunted as he followed, then Wiseclaw, while Swiftwing squeezed through after folding his wings tight.

Slotholumule entered last. For a moment, his face filled the narrow opening, rain shining on his fur.

"Keep moving," he said.

The passage dropped steeply. Stoneback used his claws to slow the descent, but the floor turned slick beneath him. A sudden current caught his shell and spun him sideways. He struck the wall hard enough to see sparks.

"Stoneback!" Thumper shouted.

"I'm here."

He dug into a seam and stopped himself. The current rushed past toward a low tunnel ahead. On the wall, just above the waterline, someone had carved the four marks.

Split circle. Three lines. Black star. Tooth.

Below them, a fifth symbol had been scratched into the stone: an open eye.

Wiseclaw reached him, breathing fast. "That mark was not on the bird."

"No," Stoneback said. "It was added later."

A low vibration traveled through the water. Somewhere beyond the tunnel, machinery woke with a distant pulse.

Slotholumule's voice came through the dark. "Can we get through?"

Stoneback looked back toward the entrance. The passage behind them had already filled with sliding mud. Above, the cult hunters shouted. Their voices echoed down the crack, distorted until they sounded like one angry throat.

He studied the carved marks again. The open eye pointed toward the current.

"The route continues," he said. "But it is not an escape tunnel."

"What is it?" Thumper asked.

Stoneback placed one claw against the vibrating stone. "A station."

The word settled among them.

The cult's northern network was not a vague threat beyond the ridge. It had a door, a current, and power running beneath the uncharted forest.

Slotholumule moved beside him, water dripping from his shirt. "Then we find what it is sending."

Wiseclaw's eyes narrowed. "We have no idea how large the station is."

"We know what happens when lies travel unchecked," Slotholumule said. "They reach every clearing."

Stoneback felt the weight of the map inside Slotholumule's grip, and the ache spreading across his shell. He had wanted certainty before committing them. The forest had offered something harsher: enough truth to make retreat impossible.

He turned toward the tunnel.

"The middle stream will carry us beneath the cliff," he said. "After that, the passage forks. The warmer current leads to the machinery."

Thumper swallowed. "And the colder one?"

"Back toward the valley."

Swiftwing's feathers brushed the stone. "Then we take the warm current."

A tremor shuddered through the passage. Dust sifted from above. Behind them, the hunters began tearing at the mud-choked entrance.

Stoneback pushed into the current. It seized him at once, dragging him toward the dark. He locked his claws around a jut of rock until the others passed, then released his grip.

The tunnel swallowed them.

For several breaths there was only rushing water, the scrape of shells and paws, and the faint electric taste of the air. Then the passage widened. Stoneback surfaced beneath a ceiling of black rock.

Ahead, a red glow pulsed through the water like a warning beacon.

Slotholumule climbed onto a narrow ledge and unfolded the map. The hidden route ended exactly where they stood.

Beyond the ledge, metal stairs descended into a chamber carved beneath the northern forest. Cables disappeared into the walls. A glass panel flickered with a crude image of the forest, divided into districts. One section remained dark.

At its center, a single label appeared.

NORTHERN STATION: ACTIVE.

Stoneback stared at the words. The uncharted territory had not been empty. It had been watching.

Slotholumule folded the map and tucked it beneath his shirt.

"We leave the familiar paths behind," he said. "From here, we move through the station."

Stoneback looked once toward the tunnel they had entered. The hunters' voices were closer now. Then he faced the red light and followed Slotholumule down the metal stairs, while far above them the northern forest carried the cult's signal into places no map had ever named.

CHAPTER 19

The Team Reassembles for Deeper Truth

The red light beneath the station flickered across Slotholumule's claws as the metal stairs shuddered under his weight.

Was he leading them toward truth, or only toward another place where someone would be hurt because he had asked them to follow?

Behind him, Stoneback's shell scraped the railing. Swiftwing's wings beat once in the narrow passage, stirring the cold, oily air. Thumper's paws touched each step with careful silence. Wiseclaw came last, clutching the recording crystal beneath his cloak.

The tunnel opened without warning.

They emerged into a ring of standing stones at the edge of the northern forest, where moonlight spilled through torn clouds and silvered the map spread across the flat center stone. The map had been crude when they first found it. Now Wiseclaw had pressed the hidden layer against its surface, and thin blue lines glowed beneath the ink.

The lines did not stop at the station.

They continued beyond the northern ridge, crossing blank country marked only by a black circle and the open-eye symbol.

Slotholumule wanted one thing before dawn: a plan the whole team could accept. Not a command forced through fear. Not another desperate charge into a place none of them understood. They needed to know where the signal led, what the cult had

hidden beyond the mapped forest, and whether the Voice Engine had been only one piece of a larger machine.

He reached for the map.

Swiftwing dropped from the nearest stone and blocked him with one outstretched wing. "No."

Slotholumule stopped. "No?"

"We just escaped a station full of hunters," she said. "You are bleeding through your sleeve, Stoneback can barely climb, and Thumper has not eaten since yesterday. You do not get to point at a blank space and call it our next mission."

Thumper's ears lowered. "She has a point."

Stoneback eased himself onto the meeting stone. Dust clung to the ridges of his shell. "The station was not empty. Something was transmitting from deeper inside."

Wiseclaw placed the recording crystal beside the map. Its faint pulse painted his face blue. "The crystal caught fragments of the transmission. Names, routes, supply marks. The cult has been moving information through more than the crater."

Slotholumule looked at the glowing lines. "Then we follow them."

"Because you are afraid to stop?" Swiftwing asked.

The question struck harder than any cult dart.

He glanced at the torn cloth over his arm. Beneath it, the old 4M FACE slogan showed through the mud. Fairness for all creatures. Peace without surrender. He had spoken those words in crowded clearings and on mountain ridges while the cult twisted every message into a weapon.

But Stoneback's shell was scratched from the last fight. Ex-Member was gone. The memory of that sacrifice pressed behind Slotholumule's eyes: a cloaked figure holding

the chamber open while the team reached the global communications device, then vanishing beneath the roar of collapsing machinery.

He had promised to protect those who could not protect themselves.

He had not promised to spend everyone who believed him.

"I am afraid," Slotholumule said.

The stones seemed to draw closer around them.

Thumper looked up. Swiftwing's wing slowly lowered. Stoneback studied him without judgment.

Slotholumule placed both claws on the map. "I am afraid that if we go on, I will ask you to make the same sacrifice Ex-Member made. I am afraid that if we stop, the cult will fill every empty place with its lies. And I am afraid I have started believing that moving forward is the only proof I can give that their victory did not matter."

Wiseclaw's fingers tightened around the crystal. "Their victory did not matter because we destroyed the device."

"Did we?" Swiftwing pointed to the blue lines. "The Voice Engine is gone. The signal is not."

A gust swept through the stones. The map's edges lifted, and Thumper pinned them down with both paws.

Stoneback gave a dry, tired laugh. "There. That is the complication."

Thumper frowned. "The wind?"

"The truth," Stoneback said. "It refuses to stay where we leave it."

Wiseclaw turned the recording crystal. A broken voice rose from it, warped by static.

" - secondary relay beyond the northern boundary - "

The message cut out. Then another voice followed, calm and unfamiliar.

" - the crater was only the first gate - "

Swiftwing's feathers lifted. "That is not the Cult Leader."

"No," Wiseclaw said. "It is not."

Slotholumule felt the old fear change shape. It was no longer fear of charging into darkness. It was fear of discovering that the darkness had no single face to defeat.

He looked from one companion to the next. "We do not enter the northern territory tonight."

Swiftwing's eyes narrowed. "You said the next territory demands immediate action."

"Investigation demands immediate action. Entering blind does not." He pulled the map toward him and folded it along the glowing route. "At first light, we send word to Roost and Perry. Perry the Possum knows the relay markings. Roost can watch the ridge and track movement. Wiseclaw will preserve every fragment from the crystal. Swiftwing, you scout the boundary, but you do not cross it alone."

Swiftwing considered him. "And you?"

"I stay with the team."

The answer surprised even him. For weeks, he had placed himself at the front because his body could endure long climbs and because the others trusted his resolve. Now he understood that leadership was not standing where danger struck first. It was making room for every voice before danger arrived.

Thumper touched the edge of the map. "What do I do?"

"You know the forest paths better than any of us," Slotholumule said. "You mark safe routes and places where the ground has been disturbed. If the relay reaches the villages, we need to know before the message reaches them."

Stoneback lifted his head. "And me?"

"You keep us from mistaking speed for strength."

Stoneback's smile was small but real. "A heavy assignment."

Swiftwing stepped around the stone and leaned over the map. "There is something else. The open-eye mark appears three times. Once at the station entrance, once beside the northern route, and once here."

She tapped a faint symbol near the bottom edge.

Wiseclaw bent close. "That mark was hidden under the cult's old boundary ink."

Slotholumule scraped away a flake of dirt with one claw. Beneath it, a second line appeared, running south instead of north. It ended at a tiny drawn circle beyond the forest's known settlements.

Thumper's whiskers trembled. "There are two relays."

"Or two places pretending to be relays," Swiftwing said.

"Either way," Wiseclaw murmured, "the network is wider than the crater."

Slotholumule stared at the crossing lines. The cult had wanted one stern voice to control every creature's understanding of the world. They had destroyed its central device, but the routes remained, carrying fragments of the same ambition through hidden stations and altered signals.

The next mission could not be a single strike. It had to uncover who else had built the network, who had funded it, and who benefited when truth became difficult to find.

He folded the map once more, then held out his hand.

"Together," he said. "No one moves without the others knowing. No secret orders. No sacrifice decided by one person alone."

Swiftwing placed her wing against his claw. "Together."

Thumper added a paw. "Together."

Stoneback pressed two thick fingers to the stack. "Slowly, if necessary."

Wiseclaw set the recording crystal on top. "And with proof."

For a moment, the ring of stones held only the sound of their breathing and the distant rush of water under the forest floor.

Then a sharp click came from the map.

All five turned.

A pin of red light appeared beneath the folded paper, pulsing in time with the crystal.

Wiseclaw snatched the map open. The blue route had changed. A thin red line now stretched from the northern station toward the stone ring, ending directly beneath their feet.

Thumper backed away. "It followed us?"

"No," Swiftwing whispered. "It was waiting."

Slotholumule felt the fear return, colder now, but he did not step back. He placed one claw over the red mark.

The stone beneath it vibrated.

From somewhere beyond the ridge, hidden among the trees, came a faint mechanical call. Not a bird this time. Not a voice. A signal answering another signal.

Stoneback rose with effort. "We have our first lead."

Slotholumule looked at his united team, then at the dark forest beyond the stones. The plan was set, but the truth ahead belonged to something larger than Flat Earth

HQ, larger than the stern human who had tried to rewrite history with a machine.

"Then we begin at dawn," he said. "And we find out who else is listening."

The red light pulsed once beneath his claw.

Far beyond the ring, another light answered.

CHAPTER 20

Ready to Uncover What's Buried

The answering light blinked again, deep beyond the northern trees.

Swiftwing tightened her grip on the edge of the broken relay panel. Cold metal pressed against her talons, and the smell of wet earth rose from the clearing below. Behind her, Stoneback shifted his weight with a quiet scrape of shell against stone. The climb had reopened the cut along his side, but he refused to rest.

"There," Roost whispered. "It's not an echo. Something is answering us."

The red pulse vanished. For a breath, the forest became a wall of black trunks and dripping leaves.

Then a third light flickered farther north.

Swiftwing spread her wings, testing the heavy air. "We can't follow that from here. The trees are too thick for flight, and the ground route is broken."

Slotholumule stepped beside her. Mud darkened his 4M FACE shirt, and one sleeve was torn from the escape beneath the crater. He looked toward the uncharted border, where vines knitted the forest into a green barricade.

"We follow it on the ground," he said. "Quietly. We find the relay before it sends another message."

Wiseclaw lowered the enhanced map. Its thin surface trembled in the wind. "The route marked beyond the ring has no stable trail. The station showed three possible passages. Two end at drops."

"Then we take the third," Thumper said.

Stoneback gave a low rumble. "And if the third ends at a drop?"

"Then we build a bridge," Thumper replied.

No one laughed. The forest still carried the memory of the crater: the broken Voice Engine, the Cult Leader's stolen broadcasts, and the Ex-Member's final sacrifice. They had stopped the machine from rewriting the forest's words. They had not stopped every signal.

Swiftwing looked at Slotholumule. "Our first goal is reaching the border without splitting up. After that, we decide whether the signal is a warning, a trap, or a call for help."

Slotholumule nodded. "No one moves alone."

They entered the trees.

The uncharted forest swallowed them within a dozen steps. Branches clawed at Swiftwing's feathers. Wet leaves slapped her face when she hopped from root to root, and the ground shifted beneath the team like loose cloth. Behind them, the clearing disappeared. Ahead, red moss glimmered faintly along the trunks, marking a path no map had recorded.

Roost flew low between the branches, his wings brushing leaves. "The marks continue north."

"Keep your voice down," Wiseclaw warned.

"I am keeping it down."

A sharp crack sounded to the left.

Everyone froze.

Swiftwing lifted her head. The scent of crushed fern drifted through the rain, fresh and bitter. Something had passed nearby.

Stoneback angled his body toward the sound. "We're being watched."

A stone dropped from the canopy and struck the ground beside Thumper. The rabbit sprang back. A second stone followed, then a third, each tied to a thread of pale vine.

"Move!" Slotholumule shouted.

The vine snapped tight.

The forest floor lurched. Roots tore upward, flinging mud across the path. Swiftwing beat her wings and rose just as a curtain of thorn branches swung through the space where her head had been. Thumper tumbled beneath it. Stoneback braced against the roots, but the trap dragged him sideways.

"Stoneback!" Swiftwing cried.

She dove, seized the strap of his travel pack, and pulled. The leather cut into her talons. Stoneback's weight nearly dragged her into the snare, but Thumper dug his heels into the mud and grabbed Swiftwing's leg.

"Pull together!"

Slotholumule crawled beneath the whipping branches. He reached the knot at the root and pressed his claws into the wet cord. The vine tightened around his wrist.

"Don't cut it," Wiseclaw called. "It's alive. Cutting may trigger another release."

Slotholumule stopped. He studied the vine as it pulsed beneath his claws. Then he turned his wrist, following the pressure instead of fighting it. The cord loosened a fraction.

"Thumper, when I say, jump left."

"Why left?"

"Because right is where the next trap is buried."

A faint metallic click answered from the mud.

"Now!"

Thumper sprang. Slotholumule twisted hard, guiding the vine around the root rather than against it. Swiftwing hauled Stoneback free, and the four of them crashed into a bank of moss as a row of sharpened branches burst from the ground.

The trap snapped shut behind them.

For several seconds, the only sound was rain ticking on leaves.

Stoneback pushed himself upright. "That wasn't cult equipment."

Wiseclaw brushed mud from the map. "No. The cult uses metal, wire, and marked darts. This was made from the forest."

Swiftwing looked up into the layered canopy. "By whom?"

A pale feather drifted down between the branches.

It was not hers.

Roost caught it before it touched the ground. A narrow red line had been painted across its shaft.

"Someone knows we're here," he said.

Slotholumule rose slowly. "Then we make sure they know why."

He moved to the red moss and placed one claw beside the nearest mark. Beneath it, nearly hidden by damp bark, lay a symbol: an open eye crossed by four short lines.

Swiftwing felt the same cold she had felt when the distant light answered them.

"Four marks," she murmured. "The message from the mechanical bird."

Wiseclaw leaned closer. "The symbol wasn't in the station records."

"Maybe it wasn't meant for the station," Roost said.

A rustle passed through the canopy. Swiftwing launched upward, threading between branches until the forest opened above her. She saw no creature, no cult patrol, no cloak. Only rain, dark leaves, and a narrow ridge running north like the spine of a sleeping animal.

At the ridge's far end, a red light blinked.

Swiftwing dropped back to the group. "The signal is beyond the ridge. We can reach it before night if the ground holds."

"The ground won't hold," Wiseclaw said. "Look."

A long fissure split the path ahead. It ran beneath tangled roots and vanished into fog. Across the gap, the red moss continued.

Thumper crouched at the edge. "That's wider than it looked."

Stoneback examined the surrounding trees. "The roots are strong enough to carry one at a time."

"Not me," Roost said. "The branch will break."

Swiftwing scanned the canopy. A fallen trunk bridged part of the fissure, but its upper half had lodged against a leaning tree. The trunk shuddered whenever the wind moved through the branches.

"We cross there," she said.

Slotholumule looked at the gap, then at Stoneback's injured side. "Stoneback goes last."

"I go first," Stoneback said.

"You're hurt."

"I'm also the heaviest. If it holds for me, it holds for the rest."

Swiftwing expected Slotholumule to argue. Instead, he placed one claw against Stoneback's shell.

"Then we test it together."

They reached the fallen trunk. Stoneback climbed onto it, gripping the slick bark. Slotholumule followed close behind, one hand ready at Stoneback's shoulder. The trunk groaned. Below, white mist curled through the fissure, carrying the smell of deep water.

Halfway across, the leaning tree shifted.

The trunk rolled.

Stoneback dropped to one knee. Swiftwing flapped hard, trying to counter the motion, but the wind shoved her sideways. Thumper cried out as his hind foot slipped from the bank.

Slotholumule seized Thumper's forearm.

"Don't look down," he said.

"I wasn't planning to!"

The trunk rolled another inch. Stoneback's claws scraped uselessly against the bark.

Swiftwing spotted a loop of vine hanging from the leaning tree. She dove, caught it in her beak, and pulled with all her strength. The vine stretched, then wrapped around the trunk. Roost joined her, gripping the same vine with his talons.

"Now!" Swiftwing shouted.

Slotholumule drove his claws into the bark and pushed. Stoneback shifted his weight toward the far bank. The trunk steadied long enough for Thumper to scramble across.

One by one, they reached the other side. The moment Stoneback stepped onto solid ground, the vine tore free. The trunk rolled into the mist and vanished with a booming splash.

No one spoke.

Then Stoneback lowered himself against a tree. His breathing came rough and shallow.

Slotholumule knelt beside him. "We should stop."

"The light is moving," Roost said.

Across the ridge, the red signal blinked twice in quick succession.

Swiftwing watched it through the rain. "It knows we're close."

Stoneback's eyes hardened. "And whatever is sending it knows we're slow."

Slotholumule looked back at the fissure. The route behind them was gone. Ahead lay the ridge, the red moss, and a forest no one had mapped.

"We continue," he said. "But we change formation. Swiftwing and Roost scout above. Wiseclaw stays with Stoneback. Thumper watches the ground. I take the front."

Swiftwing wanted to object. The leader had already carried too much from the crater, and his body moved with the careful stiffness of someone refusing to admit exhaustion. But his gaze remained fixed on the red light.

She nodded. "I'll signal if I see movement."

They climbed.

The ridge narrowed between towering trees. Their roots formed walls around the path, and cold water streamed down the bark. Swiftwing flew ahead in short bursts, never high enough to lose sight of the others. Each time she found a red mark, it pointed farther north.

At the crest, she saw the source of the signal.

A thin metal mast rose from a hollow in the forest. Its red lamp pulsed beneath a hood of leaves. Cables ran from its base into the ground, vanishing beneath roots.

Around the mast stood four wooden posts, each carved with the open-eye symbol.

Swiftwing landed on the nearest branch and signaled below.

Slotholumule climbed into the hollow. The team gathered behind him, silent and soaked. The mast hummed softly. Not the harsh mechanical whine of the Voice Engine. This sound was lower, almost like a heartbeat.

Wiseclaw touched one cable. "It's active."

"Can we shut it down?" Thumper asked.

"Not without knowing what it connects to."

A voice came from the trees.

"You should have stayed near the crater."

Swiftwing spun toward it. A figure stood beyond the posts, wrapped in a dark cloak. The face remained hidden, but a small metal badge glinted at the throat.

Stoneback shifted forward. "Cult."

The figure raised both hands. "No. Not anymore."

Slotholumule stepped between the stranger and the others. "Then show us your face."

The figure hesitated. "The network beyond this forest is not controlled by the Cult Leader. It was built before him. He found one door and mistook it for the whole house."

"Who built it?" Wiseclaw asked.

The stranger looked at the pulsing mast. "Those who believed truth belonged only to those strong enough to protect it."

"That sounds like the cult," Swiftwing said.

"It became the cult." The figure's voice tightened. "The deeper relays are still operating. Some carry warnings. Some carry commands. Some alter records before anyone knows they were changed."

Slotholumule's claws curled. "And you expect us to trust you?"

"No." The figure reached into the cloak and placed a small glass disk on the ground. Inside it, a red line moved across a map of the forest. "Trust what you can verify."

Wiseclaw picked up the disk. Light spilled across his face. New routes appeared beyond the ridge, stretching toward distant settlements and rivers. At the center of them all glowed a symbol larger than the one carved on the posts.

An open eye surrounded by four marks.

Swiftwing felt the forest tilt beneath her.

The stranger stepped backward. "The next relay is already awake. If you follow the signal, you will find proof. You will also find those guarding it."

"Are you coming with us?" Thumper asked.

The figure looked toward the south, where the crater lay hidden beyond miles of trees.

"I have already run once."

Slotholumule studied the stranger for a long moment. Then he picked up the glass disk and handed it to Wiseclaw.

"We don't need a promise," he said. "We need the truth."

The stranger lowered the hood just enough to reveal tired eyes. "Then keep walking."

A branch snapped behind them.

Swiftwing shot upward. Far down the southern slope, black shapes moved between the trees. Metal flashed. Cult hunters had found the ridge.

"Company," she called.

Slotholumule turned toward the northern forest. "Everyone move."

The team plunged through the open-eye posts as the first dart struck the mast. Red sparks burst across the hollow. Swiftwing flew low, guiding them between thorn walls and slick roots while Roost shouted directions from above.

Behind them, the mast began to pulse faster.

The stranger remained in the hollow.

Swiftwing looked back once. The cloaked figure stood beside the damaged relay, facing the hunters alone. Then the trees closed, and the red light disappeared.

Slotholumule led them into a passage so dense that even Swiftwing had to fold her wings. Branches scraped their backs. Mud sucked at their feet. No marked trail waited ahead, only the faint glow of the glass disk and the distant, answering pulse of another relay.

Stoneback limped but kept pace. Thumper stayed close to Wiseclaw. Roost circled wherever the canopy allowed.

Swiftwing brought up the rear until the last glimpse of the ridge vanished behind leaves. She listened for pursuit. The hunters' voices faded, swallowed by rain and

distance.

Ahead, the forest opened into darkness deeper than night.

Slotholumule paused at its edge.

“Still with us?” he asked.

Swiftwing folded her wings against her sides. “Until we know what’s sending those lights.”

He nodded, and the team crossed into the uncharted green.

Behind them, the old forest ended without a marker. Ahead, the next red signal waited among unknown trees, carrying a message no confirmed ally had yet claimed.

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First Edition: September 2026